



# The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

NEW DELHI, LATE CITY, 18 PAGES

₹7.00 (₹8 RAIPUR, ₹15 SRINAGAR) • www.indianexpress.com

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INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 25~05~2026

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All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination. There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

SOME BUMPS AS U.S. MODERNISING MIGRATION SYSTEM, TRADE AGREEMENT TO BE SIGNED SOON, SAYS RUBIO

## US-India strategic alliance, global influence: Rubio

Asked about ties with Pakistan, US Secy of State says: We work at tactical level

Shubhajit Roy  
New Delhi, May 24

SEEKING TO repair ties between India and the United States — which he described as a “strategic alliance between two countries that have global influence and the ability to influence global events” — visiting US Secretary of State Marco Rubio on Sunday addressed New Delhi’s concerns on challenges over the past year — from trade tariffs to visa restrictions and changes in immigration policies to Washington’s close ties with Pakistan’s military leadership.

Rubio underlined that the changes “whether trade tariffs or visa curbs” were not targeted at India, but were being applied globally. Saying that the US was in the process of “modernising” its “migration system”, he said there may be “bumps” during this period of transition, but the “destination” would be a more efficient system. He also said the two sides were “on the verge” of winding up a trade agreement that would be “beneficial to both” and “sustainable”.

Addressing a press conference with External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, Rubio

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US Secretary of State Marco Rubio with Minister of External Affairs S Jaishankar in New Delhi, Sunday. AP

## India can count on me 100%... anything India wants, they get: Trump

Shubhajit Roy  
New Delhi, May 24

JOINING AN event hosted by the US Embassy here to celebrate the 250th anniversary of America’s Independence Day, US President Donald Trump, in a live phone call on Sunday, assured his “100 per cent” support to India.

“I love India... I love the Prime Minister. (Narendra) Modi is great. He’s my friend, and I just want to say a very, very good evening to everybody this

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Business as Usual

By EP UNNY



## India finalises request letter for 114 Rafales, to send it to France soon

Amrita Nayak Dutta  
New Delhi, May 24

INDIA HAS finalised the Letter of Request (LoR) for the procurement of 114 Rafale fighter jets for the IAF and is expected to send it to France “very soon”, within the “next few weeks”, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Around 90 jets from this set of 114 are to be manufactured in India through a collaboration between the French manufacturer Dassault Aviation and an Indian company, while the rest will arrive in fly-away condition. Senior officials said that soon after France responds to the LoR, India will formalise the Request for Proposal (RFP) for acquisition.

An LoR is a formal government-to-government document used to initiate such procurement, under the Foreign Military Sales (FMS) or Intergovernmental Agreement (IGA) route, outlining the capabilities, quantities and technical

requirements needed.

In such procurements, the Defence Acquisition Council (DAC) first grants its approval, following which the LoR is issued. Once the foreign government responds, mentioning the price, availability and logistical support, negotiations take place between the two sides. The Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS) has to grant approval before the final contract is signed.

In this case, the LoR came three months after the DAC cleared the long-awaited proposal to buy the Rafales under an inter-governmental deal. IAF Chief Air Chief Marshal AP Singh is scheduled to visit France early next month before Prime Minister Narendra Modi visits later in June.

The IAF already operates 36 Rafales, and the Navy is set to induct 26 Rafale M aircraft for carrier operations over the next few years. The procurement of additional Rafales will help

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## Bengal to set up ‘holding centres’ for illegal Bangla immigrants, Rohingya

Ravik Bhattacharya  
Kolkata, May 24

THE WEST Bengal government has ordered the setting up of “holding centres” across all 23 districts in the state for Bangladesh nationals and Rohingya people found to be illegally staying in the country, ahead of their deportation.

The state’s Home and Hill Affairs Department issued the

order, dated May 23, to all District Magistrates and copied it to superintendents of police, all police commissionerates, the Foreigners Regional Registration Office (FRRO), as well as the West Bengal DG and IGPs.

The order included the “procedure to be followed for deportation of Bangladeshi/Rohingya apprehended for staying illegally in this country”.

“In this connection, it is re-

quested to take initiative/appropriate action for setting up of Holding Centres in the district for apprehended foreigners as well as for the released foreign prisoners awaiting deportation/repatriation in accordance with MHA (Union Ministry of Home Affairs) guidelines...,” the order said.

All districts, especially in border areas, have been put on

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## Strategic alliance

assured that the bilateral relationship between India and the US continues to be strong and has not lost any momentum. The two ministers held their bilateral meeting on Sunday, a day after Rubio met Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

“There are only a handful of countries in the world that have both the economic and diplomatic power to be influential on strategic issues from a global perspective, and India is one of them, which is what adds the finishing touches on the importance of the strategic alliance... we have a strategic alliance between the US and India, it's a strategic alliance between two countries that have global influence and the ability to influence global events, and that distinguishes it from other relationships,” Rubio said.

Stating that the Indian government follows a “India First policy” just like the Trump administration's “America First policy”, Jaishankar, who was calibrated in his comments, stuck to the “strategic partnership” line. “We have a strategic partnership which emanates from a convergence of national interests in many areas,” he said. He outlined issues of defence, energy, nuclear energy, critical minerals and the trade negotiations as part of the bilateral talks, apart from geopolitical issues in West Asia and the Indo-Pacific.

“We discussed the importance of taking into account the Make in India approach and lessons drawn from recent conflicts, while going forward in the defence domain. On the economic front, we spoke about the value of concluding at an early date the final text of the interim agreement regarding reciprocal and mutually beneficial trade,” Jaishankar said.

The two sides discussed strengthening their strategic

partnership, with the focus on defence, security and economic cooperation. Key points from the bilateral talks include the renewal of the 10-year major defence partnership framework and the signing of a comprehensive underwater domain awareness roadmap.

Rubio, who is also the National Security Advisor in the Trump administration, also met NSA Ajit Doval.

### Visa curbs

Raising the issue of visa curbs faced by Indians, Jaishankar said: “People-to-people ties are at the heart of our relationship. I apprised Secretary Rubio of challenges that legitimate travellers face in respect of visa issuance, while we cooperate to deal with illegal and irregular mobility. Our expectation is that legal mobility would not be adversely impacted as a consequence. After all, this is very relevant to our business, technology, and research cooperation.”

Asked about the impact of the recent curbs on Indians travelling to the US, Rubio acknowledged the contribution that Indians have made to the US economy. “Over \$20 billion has been invested in the US economy by Indian companies. We want that number to continue to increase, and obviously the expertise as well that they've provided into our economy has been very, very valuable,” he said.

“...The changes that are happening now, or the modernisation of our migration system into the US, is not India-focused. It's not India-specific. It is global. It's being applied across the world. We are in a period of modernisation,” he said. “We've had a migratory crisis in the US. This is not because of India, but broadly, we had over 20 million

people illegally enter the US over the last few years, and we've had to address that challenge,” he said.

“We are modernising the US immigration system for the 21st century, so that it is an immigration system that's not just good for America, but is also good for the people that are coming... I want to be clear that the changes, while they may be having a disproportionate impact on a place like India that provides so many high-skilled workers to the US economy, it is not a system that is targeted at India, it is one that's being applied globally. But we're in a period of transition, and like any period of transition, there's going to be some bumps on that road, but we think ultimately our destination is going to be a better, more efficient system and more sustainable”.

Responding to questions on racist comments against Indians and Indian-Americans, Rubio said: “Look, I'm sure that there are people that have made comments online and in other places, because every country in the world has stupid people. I'm sure there's stupid people here. There's stupid people in the US that make dumb comments all the time. I don't know what else to tell you, other than the US is a very welcoming country.”

### Trade talks

“The US-India relationship has not lost any momentum. I understand why some people might say that... The reality of it is, this is not about India, this is about the US, in terms of trade. The President did not say, 'Let's figure out a way to create friction with India over trade'. The President came in and said, 'We have a trade situation involving the US economy that doesn't work moving forward. There's a huge imbalance that's built up, and it needs to be addressed'. And he pursued it from a global perspective,” Rubio said.

“As Secretary of State, there

## E. EXPLAINED

### Bid to repair ties

New Delhi and Washington have had a challenging year where strategic trust has been a major casualty. Marco Rubio's remarks are an important outreach towards the Indian government, and part of Washington's diplomacy towards its partner in the region and a member of Quad.

is virtually no country in the world that I could travel to that isn't going to raise the issue of trade, because we did this from a global perspective. The President approached it and said we have to rebalance US trade, and one of the reasons why is, again, this is not about India... The US was being de-industrialised, we pursued trade policies that left us in a place where all the means of production had been outsourced in such a way that left us vulnerable. That had to change, and it cost us jobs to create a huge displacement in our country, and that needed to be corrected. There needs to be a rebalancing of how we approach global trade,” he said.

“The good news is that through this rebalancing, we are ultimately seeking, and believe we will arrive at, trade arrangements around the world that are good for the US, and also for our trade partners, and one of those we hope will be India. In fact, we are on the verge of making that happen. We are hopeful that our trade representative can visit here very soon. We had an Indian delegation in the US, I believe, last week or the week before. We've made tremendous progress, and I think we're going to wind up with a trade agreement between the US and India that's going to be enduring, and it's going to be beneficial to both sides and sustainable in a way that addresses this national in-

terest that we have,” he said.

Rubio listed areas of cooperation, including on Pax Silica, an initiative on critical minerals. “This is an area of strategic concern for both sides... In just the last few months, as I said, there's \$20 billion of Indian investment in the US economy, and that number continues to grow, so I think the relationship continues to be strong. In fact, I believe by the end of this administration it will be stronger than it's ever been. That's certainly our goal, and that's certainly what we're building towards,” he said.

### US-Pakistan ties

On the Trump administration's close ties with Pakistan's military leadership, Rubio said: “As far as our relations with other countries... we have relations, and we work at the tactical level, for example, and in many other ways, with countries all over the world; so does India. That's what responsible nation states do. But I don't view our relation with any country in the world as coming at the expense of our strategic alliance with India.”

He underlined that “India is an important strategic partner... one of our most important strategic partners in the world”.

### Hormuz closure

On Iran's closure of the Strait of Hormuz, Rubio said: “This is an international waterway... they don't own it. It's an international waterway, and what they are doing now is basically threatening to destroy commercial vessels using an international waterway. That is illegal under any concept of international law that governs us... if we allowed that to become normal, we would be normalising an unacceptable status quo and setting a dangerous precedent that could be replicated here in this region and in multiple places around the world. So, the President has his preference... to find a diplomatic way that these problems can be solved.”

## ‘Holding centres’

alert and tasked with identifying those staying “illegally”. According to sources, after such people are identified, they will be put in the holding centres. Later, they will be handed over to the BSF for a “push back” into Bangladesh.

Speaking to reporters in Kolkata on the issue, Union Minister of State Sukanta Majumdar said, “Union Home Minister (Amit Shah) on multiple occasions said that illegal infiltration will not be tolerated. Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari also made it clear that if there is any Bangladeshi infiltrator here, police will catch them and then hand them over to the BSF... Why should we pay

and feed people who have come from another country? We will send them back. I had a talk with the Chief Minister yesterday. The government will prepare a list of such persons.”

The BJP, which came to power for the first time in West Bengal earlier this month, has made it clear that tackling illegal immigration is one of its major priorities. In the first Cabinet meeting, it was decided that land would be given to the BSF to undertake fencing along the Bangladesh border, and the work for this has been underway on a war footing.

In a press conference on May 20, Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari said his gov-

ernment would follow the “detect, delete and deport” system for illegal Bangladeshis in Bengal. This involves finding “illegal immigrants”, deleting their names from the voter list and welfare schemes, and then sending them back to their country of origin.

He also mentioned the Citizenship (Amendment) Act (CAA), under which Hindus, Sikhs, Buddhists, Jains, Parsis, and Christians from Afghanistan, Bangladesh, and Pakistan can apply for citizenship. “Those who are covered under CAA are safe here. Those who are not covered under CAA and illegal infiltrators will be arrested by the state police and handed over to the BSF for deportation. Our policy is detect, delete and deport,” said the Chief Minister.

## Rafales

minimise logistical and training costs.

The indigenous content of the jets would be nearly 50 per cent. While having complete access to the source code is unlikely, India has been negotiat-

ing to obtain the Interface Control Documents (ICD) for the jets, to be able to integrate indigenous weapons such as Astra and BrahMos-NG. An ICD is a technical blueprint on how an aircraft's onboard systems communicate with external weapons, sensors and equipment.

The Government is aiming

to sign the contract by the end of this year, once commercial negotiations conclude and the CCS approves the acquisition.

The process for the acquisition of modern fighter jets for IAF has picked up over the past year after a long wait of nearly 18 years. The Rafales will be critical in filling the gap in the

## Trump

morning here, and this evening there. And I just want to say, you're great. We've never been closer to India, and India can count on me 100 per cent and our country,” Trump said.

“We have a record economy, a record stock market. And anything India wants, they get. And I'm a big, big fan of Prime Minister Modi,” he said.

Trump was on speaker phone with US Ambassador Sergio Gor, who called him up at around 9 pm IST (11.30 am in Washington DC), as about 1,500 guests, including US Secretary of State Marco Rubio and External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, attended the event.

Addressing the event at Bharat Mandapam, Rubio said: “... We know that so much of what we achieved in our history has been built in partnership with other countries around the world, with which we share so much. And one of those relationships that I am so excited about going into... given the challenges and the opportunities of this new era, is India. It's one of those countries that I know that we have this very valuable strategic partnership with, and we share so many values and so many common interests.”

“I will try to go through other celebrations of our 250th birthday in different parts of the world, although I doubt any will have a production like this one, but I want you to know that part of my visit here is also to reinforce how important this relationship is, how exciting it is, and how many opportunities we have to do things together. If I think about all of the key issues and all of the key opportunities of the modern economy, India and the US together are... perfectly positioned to work together on these issues to achieve a better life for the people of the United States, for the people of India, and frankly, for the people of other countries working together as well,” he said.

“Today, our two countries approach the world with certain common attributes. We are both political democracies, we are market economies, and we are open societies. These shared traits have, in recent times, been strengthened by a convergence of national interests, and that is precisely what has enabled us to overcome the hesitations of history. Our strategic partnership is expressed now in a very wide range of activities. They span trade and investment, defence and security, critical and emerging technologies,” Jaishankar said.

Music composer A R Rahman was among those who performed at the event.

IAF's fighter squadron strength, which stands at 29 against the sanctioned strength of 42. They are expected to bridge this capability gap until the maturity of India's indigenous fighter programmes, LCA Mk1A, LCA Mk2 and the fifth-generation Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA).





# UCC will not encroach upon rights, customs, traditions of tribals: Shah

Deeptiman Tiwary  
New Delhi, May 24

SEEKING TO allay apprehensions among tribal communities over the Uniform Civil Code (UCC), Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday said that no provision of the UCC would apply to tribals and asserted that the law would not encroach upon their rights, customs or traditions.

Addressing the “Janjati Suraksha Samagam” — a massive tribal mobilisation organised by the RSS-linked Janjati Suraksha Manch (JSM) and Vanvasi Kalyan Ashram — at the Red Fort grounds, Shah said: “A conspiracy has started where it is being said that the UCC will deprive tribals of their right to follow their culture and traditions. I want to make it clear today that no provision of UCC will be applicable to tribals. UCC will not encroach upon the rights of tribals.”

The statement is significant because the UCC has long been one of the core ideological projects of the RSS and BJP, and tribal groups in several regions have expressed apprehension that a common civil code could dilute customary tribal practices and community laws.

Shah said BJP-ruled Gujarat and Uttarakhand had already made “special provisions” to keep tribals outside the ambit of the UCC. “I want you to go



Union Home Minister Amit Shah attends the Janjati Suraksha Samagam at Red Fort on Sunday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

across the country with this message. Tell people there is nothing to fear from the UCC,” he said.

Shah’s remarks came at an event that also carried strong undertones of the Sangh Parishad’s long-running ideological campaign against religious con-

versions among tribals. Referring to conversion indirectly, Shah said the Constitution gave every citizen the right to follow their “indigenous faith” with dignity, but added that “nobody can convert anyone through allurements or by force”.

“Tribals follow a range of be-

liefs and worship nature which connects us to Sanatan Dharma. Today we have to take the pledge that we will protect our faith. It is our faith that will keep us connected to our culture and even our country,” he said. The remarks are likely to be read in the backdrop of the mobilisation carried out over the past several years by the JSM — an organisation formed around 2005-06 specifically to raise the demand for delisting converted Christians from the Scheduled Tribes category. The JSM has organised rallies across tribal-dominated regions of central India and the Northeast arguing that converted tribals continue to avail reservation benefits despite moving away from indigenous faith systems.

Its national convenor Ganesha Ram Bhagat has been among the most vocal proponents of the demand, while the organisation’s co-convenor Dr Rajkishore Hansda is a long-time functionary of the RSS-affiliated Vanvasi Kalyan Ashram, which has worked among tribal communities since the 1950s and historically opposed Christian missionary activity in tribal belts.

At Sunday’s event, Shah praised Bhagat and other organisers, saying the “movement of tribal identity, unity and protection of tribal culture” launched by them was “the first movement after Bhagwan Birsa

Munda’s Ulgulan Andolan to bring the nation together”.

The gathering, organised to mark the 150th birth anniversary year of tribal icon Birsa Munda, drew participants from hundreds of tribal communities across the country. Organisers had claimed ahead of the event that over 1.5 lakh people representing more than 500 tribal groups would attend.

In his address, Shah sought to weave tribal identity into the broader Hindutva narrative. Invoking episodes from the Ramayana, he said those trying to divide society forget that “during Treta Yuga, Lord Ram, by eating berries tasted by Shabari, had taught us that we are all one,” and that “by washing the feet of Nishad Raj, Lord Ram had paid respect to tribals”.

He underlined what he described as the BJP’s political and welfare commitment to tribal communities, a constituency the party has sought aggressively to expand among over the past decade but where it still faces uneven electoral success across regions.

“The BJP has always believed in the welfare of tribals. Until Atal Bihari Vajpayee became Prime Minister, there was no Tribal Welfare Ministry,” Shah said, adding that Prime Minister Narendra Modi had increased the tribal welfare budget from Rs 28,000 crore to Rs 1.5 lakh crore.



# The Editorial Page

MONDAY, MAY 25, 2026

## The rupee problem this time is different. The solution must be, too



SAJJID Z CHINOY

the rupee depreciate — as policymakers have correctly done — to act as a shock absorber. A weaker rupee will disincentivise imports, improve export competitiveness and thereby simultaneously narrow the CAD and boost domestic activity (“expenditure switching”). Theoretically, too, a sharp slowdown in FDI compounded by a large negative terms-of-trade shock from crude prices would argue for a much more depreciated equilibrium exchange rate.

But while rupee depreciation is a necessary condition, will it be sufficient? In theory, a weaker rupee acts as an automatic stabiliser on the capital account, too, because if it is perceived to have overshot, foreign capital should be attracted back. But what does overshooting mean in the current environment? To what extent will the rupee need to depreciate — if it is the only instrument deployed — to close a large BoP gap? That is the question foreign investors are grappling with, and it’s not clear that any value of the rupee will be seen as being oversold, given the perceived size of the BoP gap.

In fact, if the rupee depreciates too rapidly, it increases the incentives for foreigners to hedge their existing stock of assets in India (FPI, ECBs, FDI), compounding BoP pressures. That hedging puts more pressure on the rupee, further increasing the desire to hedge, thereby creating a self-fulfilling spiral — signs of which have emerged. This risks pushing the rupee far away from its fundamentals and warrants a circuit breaker to restore order.

That circuit breaker should be foreign capital augmentation measures. The objective must be to attract a large enough quantum of near-term capital inflows across multiple avenues — even if it in-

volves a subsidised swap — to change exporter, importer and investor behaviour, and prevent a destabilising overshooting of the rupee.

A weaker rupee and an influx of capital should hopefully stem the tide. If not, “expenditure compression” — tighter fiscal and monetary policy — may be needed, but only as a last resort. Back in 2013, when the rupee was under pressure, it was clear the economy was overheating, and the obvious response was to tighten fiscal and monetary policy to narrow the CAD. The current context is very different: Core inflation has averaged just 2-3 per cent in recent years, suggesting the existence of slack, and we are still awaiting a private capex cycle that is likely to be further delayed amidst heightened geopolitical uncertainty. In this environment, fiscal compression that accommodates higher fuel and fertiliser subsidies by cannibalising public capex risks making policy pro-cyclical.

It’s important to realise that this BoP episode is different. The pressure point is the capital account, not the current account. This will require both a weaker rupee and foreign capital augmentation measures. Simply squeezing the current account through demand compression can, in fact, be counterproductive by slowing growth and turning off growth-sensitive capital inflows.

More generally, the biggest lesson India must draw from this episode is that attracting strong and stable FDI needs to be an urgent imperative — both for macro stability and growth. This will require sustained economic reform that improves India’s structural competitiveness. There is no escaping that imperative.

*The writer is head of Asia Economics at J.P. Morgan. Views are personal*

### The energy challenge is urgent, step up to it

THE US war on Iran has prompted a rethink on the challenges facing the Indian economy. While most of the focus at present has been on the sharp fall in the exchange rate of the rupee, the rupee’s fall isn’t, by itself, the problem. It is, rather, a reflection of the more substantive weaknesses in the economy. The biggest one is India’s high and rising dependence on energy imports. The initial response of austerity — urging people to work from home and other ways to conserve energy — could at best be a short-term fix. It is not a surprise that on his return from the five-nation tour last week, Prime Minister Narendra Modi held a meeting with his council of ministers to review the state of the economy and asked them to urgently explore alternative energy sources.

An economy such as India’s that hopes to quadruple average incomes over the next 20 years will need all the energy it can get. For instance, according to the government’s own data, between 2013-14 and 2023-24, per capita electricity consumption rose by 46 per cent. But while demand is growing fast, and is expected to grow faster, the supply of energy is a different story. Take coal, for example. India has one of the largest reserves of coal in the world and coal has remained the backbone of its energy supply, accounting for nearly 79 per cent of the total energy supplied domestically in 2024-25. Yet, the government admits in 2026 that the country has “experienced a steady dependency on imported coal over the last decade”. The net energy import dependency — an indicator that measures the extent to which a country relies on imports to meet its energy requirements — for coal is more than 23 per cent. This dependence on imports is alarmingly high and rising when it comes to crude oil (almost 90 per cent, up from 85 per cent a decade ago) and natural gas (50 per cent, up from 40 per cent a decade ago).

When it comes to a shift to renewables, India is fourth globally in renewable energy installed capacity, fourth in wind power, and third in solar power capacity. But more needs to be done, and soon. Finally, beyond finding new ways to produce and source energy with a view to reducing import dependence, India must also relook at how it uses its energy. Can it shift to electricity (produced from domestic sources) for cooking food instead of using imported gas? Or so radically improve public transport that it reduces the need for cars? Those are the questions.

THREE MONTHS into the West Asia conflict, India has done well to avoid widespread energy shortages. Further, the burden-sharing of higher energy prices between the public and private sectors has begun. Retail prices are being raised, but will need to be increased further to elicit the necessary behavioural response from households and firms.

Instead, the key pressure point remains the balance of payments (BoP) and the rupee. But there are two unique elements this time.

First, pressures have long pre-dated the West Asia conflict. For the first time in decades, the BoP has been in deficit for two consecutive years, and we are on course for a third successive deficit. This suggests a more chronic underlying phenomenon that needs to be addressed.

Second, pressures are emanating from the capital account, not the current account. In past episodes, there was a prototypical evolution: The current account deficit (CAD) widened and became more dependent on fickle capital inflows to finance it, which ultimately dried up. This put pressure on the rupee and necessitated compressing the CAD. This episode is very different. The current account deficit has remained very benign — averaging less than 1 per cent of GDP over the last three years. Instead, pressures have been driven squarely by the capital account. Capital inflows — which used to average 2.5 per cent of GDP pre-pandemic — have consistently slowed since 2023, completely dried up in 2025 and have exerted pressure on the rupee.

Making the analytical distinction between the capital and current account as the source of pressures is crucial to formulating the right response.

In turn, a collapse in FDI is at the heart of the capital flow story, with net FDI, which used to average 1.5 per cent, completely drying up since 2024. What’s driving this? Between 2010 and 2025, India’s net FDI has been strongly correlated with US 10-year treasuries — a proxy for global financial conditions. When yields are low, India tends to get a gush of FDI; when yields have hardened — as in the last two years — net FDI has completely dried up. Recall, FDI is typically governed by both (global) “push” and (country-specific) “pull-factors.” India’s FDI has largely been governed by push factors since 2010. The last time it was driven by India-specific pull-factors was in 2005-10 when a strong corporate capex cycle catalysed FDI. In contrast, Vietnam has consistently been able to attract above 4 per cent of GDP in FDI irrespective of global financial conditions.

Why does this matter? Because global financial conditions are likely to remain tight. Sticky inflation and a precarious fiscal situation are likely to keep US yields elevated. Meanwhile, India’s CAD is on course to more than double because of the West Asia conflict. Even if the Strait of Hormuz opens immediately, it is estimated crude prices will remain in triple digits all year as supply takes a while to normalise while demand remains strong to replenish inventories. If so, this would translate into India’s CAD widening close to \$100 billion this fiscal. The combination of higher bond yields and higher crude prices risks a pincer-like effect on the BoP.

The genesis of the problem, however, is a sustained slowing of capital flows, amplified only recently by the terms-of-trade shock from higher energy prices. This must inform the policy response.

The first line of defence is to let

**The pressure point is the capital account. This will require both a weaker rupee and foreign capital augmentation measures. Squeezing the current account through demand compression can be counterproductive**



## India faces a 1991 moment: It needs to reform, relook at subsidies



**FROM PLATE TO PLOUGH**  
BY ASHOK GULATI  
AND RITIKA JUNEJA

THE INDIAN rupee continues to weaken against the US dollar. If the RBI does not intervene decisively, the exchange rate could well slide to Rs100 per US dollar. To stabilise the rupee, the RBI may need a war chest of at least \$50–60 billion, and even that would provide only temporary relief. The underlying causes of the crisis lie largely beyond the RBI's control.

The crisis in the Middle East is finally hitting India pretty hard. Energy and fertiliser costs have almost doubled. The recent increase in petrol prices by around Rs 3–4 per litre is only a partial pass-through of global prices. Similar underpricing exists in LPG, LNG, and fertilisers, especially urea. These pressures are likely to widen the fiscal deficit beyond 5 per cent of GDP.

Foreign portfolio investors are losing interest in India and withdrawing their investments. Domestic investors are equally worried and are not coming forward to invest big. The IMD has forecast a strong El Niño. As a result, the Indian economy is losing momentum. Our calculation, based on today's conditions, is that in the current financial year (FY27), India will be lucky to clock 6 per cent GDP growth and contain Consumer Price Index (CPI) inflation below 6 per cent. If the Strait of Hormuz remains closed for another three months, GDP growth will fall below 6 per cent, and CPI inflation will shoot above 6 per cent — the upper band of the RBI for inflation control. The RBI will not have much choice but to raise the repo rates soon, triggering the northward movement of all interest rates. The economy seems to be on the brink of a major crisis. The only rational way



ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

to avoid this is to carry out major reforms, similar to those in 1991.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has called for austerity measures, and some chief ministers have reportedly travelled on motorcycles, metros and electric cars. Such tokenism does not last long. After returning from his five-country visit, Modi held a meeting with his cabinet colleagues and asked them to carry out reforms that can save resources, especially energy, narrow down the twin deficits of trade and current account, and restore confidence in India's growth story. The technical blueprint of economic reforms is not difficult to prepare, but what is required is the political will to undertake such reforms. The culture of distributing freebies, at the central as well as the state level, is now deeply entrenched. That's the biggest hurdle in carrying out structural reforms. Let us demonstrate with the examples of fertiliser and food subsidies.

Take the case of fertilisers first. India imports anywhere from 20 to 25 per cent of its urea requirements. The last import tender showed that the minimum price of urea's landed cost on the west

**The ultimate solution — the real 'brahmastra' — lies in reforming the entire chemical fertiliser subsidy regime by moving towards a direct benefit transfer system on a per-acre basis, integrated with the PM-Kisan scheme**

coast would be \$935/tonne. But it is being sold at less than \$70/tonne to farmers. How prudent is this? Let the readers judge. But what we know is that such pricing creates a large arbitrage — a large amount that is being diverted away from agriculture to other industrial uses in India and also smuggled out to neighbouring countries. Bihar is an interesting example. Government data on fertiliser supply and usage reveal a mismatch. While official figures show large quantities of urea, DAP, and MOP being supplied, another set of government data — the Cost of Cultivation surveys used to determine the minimum support prices for major crops — suggests that actual on-farm usage is more than 50 per cent lower than the quantity supplied. The obvious question is: Where does the rest go?

Anyone familiar with Bihar's ground realities knows that the state has long been an easy route for fertiliser diversion into Nepal. Reports from border districts also indicate that subsidised fertilisers are routinely smuggled into Bangladesh. The root cause is the enormous subsidy on urea, which today

covers nearly 90 per cent of its cost.

The fertiliser subsidy bill, budgeted at Rs 1.71 lakh crore for FY27, is almost certain to exceed Rs 2.25 lakh crore and could even touch Rs 2.50 lakh crore. The ultimate solution — the real *brahmastra* lies in reforming the entire chemical fertiliser subsidy regime by moving towards a direct benefit transfer system on a per-acre basis, integrated with the PM-Kisan scheme. Concerns relating to tenant farmers can be addressed by triangulating different data sets, provided the government gives this reform the same priority it once accorded the Jan Dhan-Aadhaar-mobile linkage initiative.

Once this transition is made, fertiliser prices should be left to market forces. That would curb leakages and the smuggling of urea, correct the imbalance in the use of nitrogen, phosphorus, and potassium, and improve nutrient use efficiency. Such reforms could save the government at least Rs 40,000–50,000 crore annually. If comprehensive reform is politically difficult, the second-best option would be to impose quantitative restrictions on fertiliser sales based on landholding size and the crops being cultivated. If even that proves unfeasible, a third alternative would be to bring urea under the nutrient-based subsidy scheme, raise urea prices gradually, and potentially reduce the prices of phosphatic and potassic fertilisers, while keeping the overall subsidy bill around Rs 2 lakh crore.

A similar issue arises with food subsidies. The food subsidy bill for FY27 is budgeted at Rs 2.28 lakh crore. Yet, if the government claims that extreme poverty has fallen to 5.3 per cent, according to World Bank standards, or around 11 per cent according to NITI Aayog's Multidimensional Poverty Index, why should free food grain continue to be distributed to more than 800 million people? Rationalising the coverage under the scheme or increasing issue prices for those above the poverty line could potentially save another Rs 50,000 crore annually.

Failing to undertake these reforms would reflect not caution, but policy timidity.

*Gulati is distinguished professor and Juneja a senior fellow at ICRIER. Views are personal*

## On media, a heavy-handed government, biased rankings



COOMI KAPOOR

THE NORWEGIAN journalist Helle Lyng opened a can of worms by sanctimoniously preaching press freedom and human rights to India. There were several takeaways from the ensuing brouhaha. The Ministry of External Affairs' long-winded discourse on India's history and civilisation in response to the question at hand as to why Norway should trust us simply digressed, unnecessarily making a mountain out of a molehill.

Lyng's query also drew attention to the fact that our articulate PM opts not to field questions from the media, either at home or abroad. Still, that is not exactly a major media freedom issue, as is being made out. Other world leaders also shy away from speaking extempore.

But what rankled many Indians was Lyng piously quoting Reporters Without Borders' 2026 Press Freedom Index, which ranked India a lowly 157th. It's true that standards of press freedom have plummeted of late. Even then, can a report card which places countries such as Burundi, Hong Kong, Singapore, Congo, Nigeria, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Kuwait and Jordan above India be taken seriously? Middle Eastern countries are ruled mostly by despotic monarchs, where a whisper against the government can lead to instant deportation or imprisonment. Indian residents are mortally afraid of even sending a WhatsApp message back home mentioning drone strikes in their neighbourhood. Countries once part of the former Soviet Union, such as Kyrgyzstan and Uzbekistan, inherited autocratic systems of secret police and detentions — these are not yet dismantled. Business-oriented Singapore views the press more as an arm to enhance nation-building than a medium to question the system.

A safe environment for journalists to work in is one of the key criteria in judging a country's standing. Yet Israel, which according to the Committee to Protect Journalists was responsible for the death of 84 journalists in the line of duty last year, is ranked much higher than India, where the committee lists just one journalist's unnatural death. The United States received a fairly respectable score of 64, though criticisms from some MAGA-

aligned and heartland media outlets of President Donald Trump's erratic and allegedly unconstitutional actions and perceived attempts to enrich his family have been limited. The most trenchant criticism in the US comes from the late-night show comedians. CBS recently ended popular comedian Stephen Colbert's show after 33 years, citing falling ad revenues. Trump publicly rejoiced at Colbert's ouster, reportedly the price for CBS's parent company, Paramount, being safeguarded from facing



trouble at the hands of the government.

Modi detractors who cite India's low rating as a consequence of his dictatorial policies will be disappointed to learn that even prior to the current dispensation, India consistently got low media freedom rankings. In February 2014, India was ranked 140. One assumes that a key indicator of a country's robust press is the plurality of opinions openly expressed on different media platforms. An illustrative example was last year's Operation Sindoor, where there were several voices on just how the four-day war with Pakistan was unfolding, from chest-thumping journalists to cynical publicly aired assessments that the Pakistan-China combine had downed five Rafale jets. Neither extreme position was accurate, but it reflected the wide range of discourse. In Pakistan's military dictatorship, where its most popular leader is still in jail, the media almost unanimously stuck to the government's story that Pakistan was victorious, even though satellite images of bombed military air bases released by India suggested otherwise.

This article is not an endorsement of the Indian government's ham-handed media policy, but simply questions Reporters Without Borders' own biases. Otherwise, why would it elevate military dictatorships and feudal overlords, from countries where popular political opponents and scribes are often jailed, above a functioning democracy, however imperfect? There is, perhaps, a prejudice against nations not in conformity with the outfit's foreign-policy goals, or inherent racism, as well as prejudice against countries with non-Abrahamic religious majorities. The recent narrative of the Cockroach Janta Party social media account going viral in a day illustrates both India's strength and weakness. The overwhelming support for the post criticising the Chief Justice's comments testifies to the openness of our society. The toxic trolling and the X account being withheld in India — on a government request citing security concerns — reflect the growing danger that India could slip to 157th place even in an unbiased ranking if such heavy-handed actions continue unchecked.

*The writer is contributing editor, The Indian Express*



ACHAL AGARWAL, SUBHASH LAKHOTIA, SUNIL MUKHI

RESEARCH INVOLVES original, creative, patient investigations and analyses to generate new knowledge. The findings are typically published in research journals following peer review by experts. Teaching and research at higher educational institutions (HEIs) are symbiotic, although hiring, promotions, awards, funding, etc. are significantly dependent upon research activity.

A higher "rank" encourages students to seek admission at an institution and thus generates greater revenue, and also facilitates enhanced public and private funds. HEIs' academic ranking on national and international platforms relies heavily on the number of research publications and their citation count, which together contribute 30 per cent of points in India's official National Institutional Ranking Framework (NIRF) and 50 per cent in the QS World University rankings.

The current quantity-dependent ranking parameters utterly fail to assess the true academic merit of research and teaching. In fact, following Goodhart's law that any measure ceases to be effective once it becomes a target, the current rankings are damaging the country's academic ecosystem.

Careful analysis of India's apparent rise in the global research scenario reflects this damage. In recent years, India has ranked third, behind the US and China, in the number of research publications, but unfortunately stands second in

**With enhanced publication and citation counts being targets, institutions push their faculty to publish more. This has promoted the emergence of 'predatory' and 'paper-mill' journals**

published papers being retracted for unethical practices. While contributing 5 per cent of global research publications, India accounted for 20 per cent of retractions in 2025. Several institutions securing top ranks have higher retractions for research misconduct. Additionally, numerous "research papers" from India appear in huge numbers in journals of dubious quality. With enhanced publication and citation counts being targets, institutions push their faculty to publish more. This has led to the emergence of "predatory" and "paper-mill" journals, citation cartels and financial incentives for so-called adjunct/visiting faculty or collaborators.

The "Stanford/Elsevier" 2025 list of the world's "top 2 per cent scientists", widely "acclaimed" in India, also reveals serious flaws. It considers publication and citation numbers to be a proxy for research quality. Twelve per cent of Indian researchers in this list have suffered at least one retraction, with one having more than 40. While this list includes 6,000-plus Indian researchers, the "top 1 per cent researchers" list by Clarivate Analytics, which penalises retractions and other misconduct, has just five.

Emphasis on research metrics has staggering financial costs, too. In the misplaced hope of improving research quality, India's public universities spend nearly Rs2,000 crore annually on research journal subscriptions, besides paying, often to poor-quality journals, huge publication charges. The inclusion of private universities will magnify this amount.

What should be done?

A fair, responsible, transparent and quality-based assessment of individual and institutional research must replace the current rankings on numerical parameters. Rather than total numbers, the quality and genuine impact of a select few papers should be critically assessed. Unethical self-citations (institutional and individual) and retractions for unethical practices must be severely penalised. The recent introduction of a "mild" penalty for retractions by NIRF is a welcome beginning, but more stringent action is essential. Unusually large numbers of publications should be examined for possible "paper-mill" activity.

Data for regular, contractual and visiting/adjunct faculty reported by HEIs need rigorous verification since these numbers are often unethically boosted. Student outcomes (for example, alumni performance) need greater emphasis while assessing teaching quality since HEIs are expected to prepare questioning minds.

India's size and diversity necessitate an autonomous Research Integrity Office to oversee and enforce ethical teaching and research practices. Promotion, identification and recognition of high-quality teaching and research across the academic ecosystem should receive the highest priority so that India's enormous talent effectively takes the country to a truly leading position.

*The writers are board members of India Research Watch, which advocates for academic ethics in India. This article is endorsed by the full board*

## We need an autonomous Research Integrity Office

## Between Russia and EU, Delhi's defence rebalancing



GULSHAN SACHDEVA

APART FROM green growth and technology, defence cooperation emerged as an important area of engagement between India and Europe during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's recent visit to Sweden, Norway, the Netherlands and Italy. The adoption of the India-Italy Defence Industrial Roadmap was an especially important development. Earlier, on the margins of the India-EU Summit in January, Delhi signed a Security and Defence Partnership (SDP) with the EU, an integral part of 'Towards 2030: A Joint India-EU Comprehensive Strategic Agenda.

If implemented well, these pacts can reshape India's defence links with the outside

world, particularly Delhi's long-standing ties with Russia. Reducing India's dependence on Russian defence supplies has also been a stated objective of both the US and Europe.

A major transformation is underway in European security, driven largely by the war in Ukraine, uncertainty over long-term American commitments, and the emergence of domains such as cyber, space, and drone warfare. Europe is returning to classical geopolitics, with a renewed focus on military deterrence. Under the ReArm Europe project (later recast as "Readiness 2030" following objections from Spain and Italy), EU member states are set to invest close to \$1 trillion in defence in the coming years.

The White Paper on European defence asserts that "the moment has come for Europe to rearm". The priority areas identified

by the document include air and missile defence, artillery systems, ammunition and missiles, drone and counter-drone capabilities, military mobility, AI, and the protection of critical infrastructure. Apart from expanding its domestic capabilities, the EU is also strengthening its security partnerships, with a particular focus on countries such as Canada and key Indo-Pacific partners, including Australia, India, Japan, and South Korea.

The India-EU SDP has to be understood in this context. As India has an ambitious

**Unless Delhi succeeds in developing robust indigenous defence platforms, India's integration into European defence supply chains is unlikely to be easy**

defence indigenisation programme, and its defence exports have now reached around \$4 billion annually, linking its defence industry to Europe seems attractive. However, a significant share of these exports is still driven by co-production and the integration of technologies based on Russian-origin platforms, including systems such as the BrahMos missile, Sukhoi components, and parts and ammunition for the T-90 and T-72 tanks.

In recent years, India has exported artillery shells to a few European countries, some of which were diverted to Ukraine. Russia has expressed concerns, but the issue has largely been managed so far, given the relatively modest scale of such exports. Unless Delhi succeeds in developing robust indigenous defence platforms, gradually reducing its dependence on Russia, India's

integration into European defence supply chains is unlikely to be easy. The White Paper on European defence identifies Russia as an enduring threat to European security.

Buying a few big-ticket items such as Rafale jets from France or submarines from Germany with limited technology transfer is very different from integrating India into European defence supply chains. India's strategy appears to be to skillfully leverage new opportunities with European partners while not abandoning its ties with the Russian defence industry. The task is far more complex than issuing measured statements on Ukraine. Deeper integration of defence industries inevitably requires alignment with wider geopolitical realities.

*The writer is professor and Jean Monnet Chair at the Centre for European Studies, JNU*



U.S. PRESIDENT SAYS ‘BOTH SIDES MUST TAKE THEIR TIME AND GET IT RIGHT’; NUCLEAR ISSUE WOULD BE ADDRESSED LATER

# Trump says no rush for Iran deal, US blockade to stay in ‘full force’

Tehran stresses differences need to be resolved

Reuters  
Washington, , May 24

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump said on Sunday he had told his representatives not to rush into any deal with Iran, appearing to dampen hopes of an imminent breakthrough in the three-month-old war that had been raised by both sides a day earlier. The US blockade on Iranian ships on the Strait of Hormuz would “remain in full force and effect until an agreement is reached, certified, and signed”, Trump wrote on Truth Social. Negotiations were progressing and the US relationship with Iran had become more professional and productive, he said. But he added: “Both sides must take their time and get it right. There can be no mistakes!” A day earlier, Trump said Washington and Iran had “largely negotiated” a memorandum of understanding on a peace deal that would reopen the Strait of Hormuz, which before the conflict carried one-fifth of global oil and liquefied natural gas shipments. Trump has repeatedly played up the prospect of an agreement to end the war that



People wave Iranian flags and hold portraits of Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei during a ceremony honouring armed forces personnel and those killed in the war, in Tehran on Sunday. AP

the US and Israel started on February 28. It was not clear whether the agreement he was referring to on Sunday was the interim memorandum of understanding that has been under discussion, or a much more challenging final peace settlement, likely to take much longer. The two sides remain at odds on several difficult issues, such as Iran’s nuclear ambitions, its demands for the lifting of sanctions and the release of tens of billions of dollars of Iranian oil revenues frozen in foreign banks, and Israel’s war in Lebanon with the Iranian-backed Hezbollah militia. Various media in the US and Iran had said the memorandum setting out a framework for ending months of fighting would, if concluded, initially lift a US blockade on Iranian vessels and reopen the waterway, which Iran has shut with threats to attack shipping. But Iran’s *Tasnim* news agency said differences remained over one or two clauses. *Tasnim* cited a source as saying there would be no final understanding if the US continued to create obstacles. In another potential stumbling block, a military adviser to Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei said Tehran had the legal right to manage the Strait of Hormuz, though it was not clear if that meant continuing to decide which ships can go through. Any deal reinforcing the current fragile ceasefire would bring relief to markets but not immediately quell a global energy crisis, which has driven up costs of fuel, fertilizer and food.

Even if the war ends now, full flows through the strait will not return before the first or second quarter of 2027, the head of the Abu Dhabi National Oil Company said last week. Iran’s Revolutionary Guards said 33 vessels had passed through the strait over the past 24 hours after getting permission from Tehran. Trump, while offering various war aims during the conflict, has repeatedly said the US struck Iran to prevent it from obtaining nuclear weapons. Iran “must understand ... that they cannot develop or procure a Nuclear Weapon or Bomb, he reiterated in his post on Sunday. Iran has long denied it is pursuing such weapons and says it has a right to enrich uranium for civilian purposes, although the purity it has achieved far exceeds that needed for power generation. Sources have told *Reuters* the proposed framework, when it emerges, will unfold in three stages: formally ending the war, resolving the crisis in the Strait, and launching a 30-day window for negotiations on a broader agreement, which can be extended. Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei said on Saturday that “the trend this week has been towards a reduction in disputes, but there are still issues that need to be discussed through mediators”.

## • U.S.-IRAN PEACE DEAL: WHAT’S ON THE TABLE

A draft understanding appears close, but major gaps remain over Tehran’s nuclear programme and the terms of sanctions relief

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|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>U.S. SIDE</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>● Trump says a preliminary peace understanding has been “largely negotiated”.</li><li>● Washington wants the Strait of Hormuz reopened.</li><li>● Iran may be asked to give up or limit its stockpile of highly enriched uranium.</li><li>● Detailed nuclear negotiations could be pushed to a later round.</li><li>● Release of frozen Iranian assets may be linked to progress on a final nuclear deal.</li><li>● U.S. officials say reconstruction-linked funding could keep Tehran engaged in talks.</li></ul> | <b>IRAN SIDE</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>● Tehran reportedly backs a memorandum to halt fighting across regional fronts.</li><li>● Iran wants the Strait of Hormuz reopened without tolls.</li><li>● It seeks lifting of the US naval blockade and broader economic relief.</li><li>● Iran reportedly wants access to nearly \$25 billion in frozen assets.</li><li>● Iranian officials say the draft does not settle the nuclear issue immediately.</li></ul> | <b>WHAT STILL NEEDS TO BE ADDRESSED</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>● Fate of Iran’s highly enriched uranium stockpile remains unresolved.</li><li>● Timeline and limits on uranium enrichment are still disputed.</li><li>● Terms and sequencing of sanctions relief remain unclear.</li><li>● Israeli and US conservative opposition could complicate final approval. NYT &amp; AP</li></ul> |
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## China sends astronaut on year-long space mission as it eyes 2030 moon landing

Reuters  
Jiuquan, May 24

CHINA SENT three astronauts to its space station on Sunday, one of whom will stay for a year, a record length for the country, enabling the study of long-duration human physiology in space as Beijing works towards its ambition of a crewed moon landing by 2030. The Shenzhou-23 vessel launched at 11:08 pm using the Long March-2F Y23 carrier rocket from Jiuquan Satellite Launch Center in northwest China, with three Chinese astronauts on board. Payload specialist Li Jiaying, a former Hong Kong police inspector, is the first astronaut from the city to take part in a Chinese space mission. The other crew members are commander Zhu Yangzhu and pilot Zhang Yuanzhi, both from the People’s Liberation Army’s astronaut division. One of the three is to stay on the Tiangong space station for a year, one of the longest space missions ever but short of the 14-

**The Shenzhou-23 vessel launched using the Long March-2F Y23 carrier rocket from Jiuquan Satellite Launch Center in northwest China**

1/2-month record set by a Russian cosmonaut in 1995. That astronaut will be decided later, depending on the progress of the mission, the China Manned Space Agency said on Saturday. China has sent astronauts to its space station almost a dozen times, but this launch comes amid an accelerating race to the moon with the US, which has warned about what it alleges are Beijing’s plans to colonise and mine lunar territory and resources. NASA is seeking to achieve a crewed moon landing in 2028, two years ahead of China. The US aims to establish a long-term lunar presence as a stepping stone to eventual human exploration of Mars.

• IN A DEVASTATED SECTION OF THE CORAL TRIANGLE IN THE PACIFIC OCEAN, A CONSERVATION GROUP IS TRYING TO BUILD AN ARTIFICIAL REEF

## On a damaged Malaysian seabed, ‘concrete’ reefs are bringing coral & fish back

Zunaira Saieed  
Pom Pom Island (Malaysia)  
May 24

THE SMALL boat set off from a tiny island in the western Pacific Ocean, its destination only a few hundred feet away. Its cargo was dozens of chunks of concrete that each weighed 60 pounds, had a textured surface and evoked a white lotus leaf. One by one, the crew tossed the pieces overboard. Then three divers descended 20 feet to the seabed with nuts, bolts and steel rods. As they began fastening the concrete pieces on top of one another, hundreds of curious damselfish gathered around them, and three green

turtles circled nearby. Within an hour, the structure was complete: an artificial reef standing 3 feet tall and 10 feet wide. This construction, on a recent Thursday morning near Pom Pom Island, Malaysia, was part of an effort to rejuvenate a small section of the Coral Triangle, which covers a wide section of Southeast Asia and is the most biodiverse marine region in the world. Pom Pom Island lies off the northeastern coast of Borneo, an area where fishermen have for decades used homemade dynamite to kill schools of fish. The practice, which has long been illegal in Malaysia, is common among local anglers, who

say they cannot earn enough money from the smaller catches they make using conventional methods. But miles of coral reef have become collateral damage. “The seabed here is like a desert, and this is one structure bringing life back,” said Robin Philippo, managing director of the Tropical Research and Conservation Center, the conservation group that installed the artificial reef. Over the past two years, the group has installed more than 60 of these structures around the island, each weighing about half a ton and costing about \$5,000. The corrugated surfaces allow corals to take hold,



The structures are made from concrete with 3-D printed molds. NYT

while the gaps between the individual pieces provide shelter from predators for marine life. “Before the structures were

placed, it was just rubble on the seabed and no fishes,” said Alvin Chelliah, chief programs officer at Reef Check Malaysia,

a nonprofit. “But now we can see damselfishes, juvenile groupers, butterfly fishes are making a comeback at the artificial reef structures.” Still, he warned, “the concrete reef is not a silver bullet.” Concrete reefs are less likely to support marine life that typically drills into natural reef surfaces, like boring giant clams, Chelliah said. In recent years, Malaysia has lost about 20% of its coral cover largely because of rising ocean temperatures that have accelerated coral bleaching, according to Reef Check Malaysia. This can have devastating consequences. For instance, the British government has warned

that a collapse of the reef system in Southeast Asia and the ensuing drop in caught fish could harm food security in Britain. Near Pom Pom Island, where the main enterprise is tourism, Philippo’s group, Tracc, is planning to install another 100 reef structures. Half of those are funded by a \$100,000 grant from the Coral Research and Development Accelerator Platform, a nonprofit based in Saudi Arabia. Tracc makes individual reef pieces using a mold made by Reef Design Lab, an Australian firm that also designs the units. Less than 18 months after the first structure was set up in the waters around Pom Pom Island,

which can be covered on foot in an hour or so, 500 young corals had settled on it, according to Tracc, where a team of five scientists is monitoring the results. “My observations show good recruitment of a wide range of organisms, like oysters, sponges and corals, attached to the structures,” said Scott Bryan, an earth scientist from Queensland University of Technology in Australia who is an adviser for the project. Tracc hopes to bring the structures to Tioman Island, a popular tourist destination off Peninsular Malaysia’s east coast. “Though it is a small area at a time,” Bryan said, “it is changing and improving.” NYT



• ENVIRONMENT

# 4-letter word everyone in Delhi needs to know: dust



SOPHIYA MATHEW

IT IS persistent, it lingers in the air. It is inhaled deep into the lungs, it even enters the bloodstream. And it carries toxic metals that can trigger disease, damage lungs, and raise cancer risk, especially among children. Meet road dust — the main villain in Delhi’s pollution story that is quietly putting your life at risk, every day. A January 2026 report by a panel of top experts constituted by the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) identified road dust as a major pollution source in Delhi because it acts as “both a primary emission and a persistent source”. The panel defined road dust broadly to include airborne dust from roads and shoulders, vehicle movement, dry soil, and road wear. It said poor road surfaces, potholes, broken edges, unpaved stretches, road-tyre-brake wear, and debris falling from the transport of construction and demolition (C&D) material all contribute to the dust load.

The report also underlined the mechanism that makes road dust difficult to control: dust deposited on road surfaces is resuspended by vehicular movement, particularly during dry conditions. This keeps pollution levels elevated even in the absence of active dust-generating activities. Mohammed Rafiuddin, Programme Lead for Clean Air at the Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW), said, “Scientifically, road dust is a very different kind of source compared to C&D dust. It is a line source (spread along a corridor), but at a construction site, the dust generated is from a point source.” In other words, road dust requires corridor-wide, routine removal and surface management, while construction dust depends on site-level containment and enforcement.

### Why it persists

A road-dust committee set up by the CAQM last year said resuspension is driven by continuous dust deposits along road edges and medians, unsuitable road infrastructure design, poor maintenance, and inadequate dust-management practices. The committee noted that dust from unpaved medians frequently blows onto carriageways. Irrigation practices can further worsen the problem, as thick hose pipes used for watering median and foot-path plantations often spill soil onto roads, which later dries and adds to dust levels. Encroachments and unauthorised parking were also flagged as operational barriers that obstruct cleaning and allow dust to accumulate. Local roads and secondary streets, the report said, are often excluded from regular maintenance schedules. “Maintenance is

## • DELHI’S ROADS CARRY A HIDDEN LOAD

**145 KG** Approx. amount of loose dust a 1-km road stretch in Delhi can hold

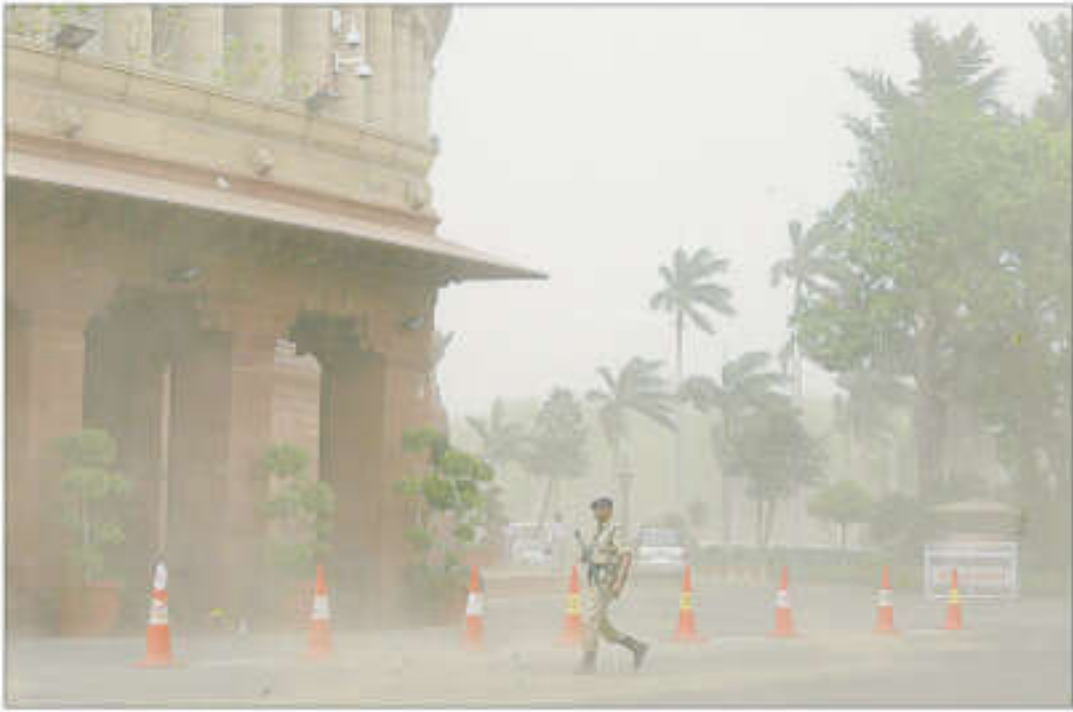
### KEY POINTS FROM VARIOUS STUDIES

#### 2016 IIT KANPUR:

- Road dust PM10 emissions in Delhi estimated at 79,626 kg/day
- Road dust PM2.5 emissions estimated at 22,165 kg/day
- North, north-east, and parts of north-west Delhi strong hotspots for road-dust resuspension-induced PM10
- These same areas overlap with low mechanical sweeping zones such as Narela, Shahdara North and Civil Lines
- Areas with relatively higher sweeping coverage, Shahdara South, Rohini and Keshavpuram, had much lower levels of road dust, as per the spatial mapping

#### 2023 IIT KANPUR, IIT DELHI, TERI REPORT:

- Road silt load in Delhi ranged from 2 to 12.5 g/m<sup>2</sup>. Reducing it below 2 g/m<sup>2</sup> recommended, with regular vacuum sweeping
- This means a 1-km × 10-metre road stretch can hold ~144.7 kg road dust



Aravalli degradation has weakened a natural dust barrier around Delhi.

- Average Delhi road silt load was around 14.47 g/m<sup>2</sup>
- Delhi road silt load near construction sites reaching about 40 g/m<sup>2</sup>, considered high for urban roads in India

Beyond smoke and car exhaust, a critical pollutant in the city is toxic dust hiding in plain sight. Common solutions offer limited benefits

### What can be fixed — what can’t

Experts say Delhi’s natural environment places it at a disadvantage. Rafiuddin said that even with improved road conditions, “there is bound to be some amount of dust always”, which then needs to be actively removed and managed. This is due to the city’s natural baseline for dust from dry summers, frequent dust storms, loose alluvial soil, and relatively low rainfall. Some commonly used mitigation measures offer limited benefits. Dipankar Saha, former head of the air laboratory at the Central Pollution Control Board, who led a 2017 pilot study on the efficacy of anti-smog guns, said such measures are ineffective for dust control. “There should not be a reliance on water sprinklers or mist guns. They only transport dust from one area to another. Once the particles settle and the surface dries, the dust is re-suspended again. It also leads to humidification,” he said. The CAQM-appointed road-dust committee said in its 2025 report that anti-smog guns “should be deployed selectively on high priority situations”, recommending their use only in emergencies and describing them as “a lower priority for dust control on roads”.

Instead, the committee called for a standardised framework that combines paving, greening within the right-of-way, and improved maintenance practices, explicitly stating that solutions must go beyond sweeping alone. On greening, the report said vegetation helps by arresting airborne dust and preventing resuspension from unpaved areas. It recommended roadside planting with drought-resilient species that are better at trapping dust, such as those with wide canopies and rough or large leaf surfaces. It also suggested practical design measures, including leaving an 8-12 inch gap between soil level and the top of kerb stones to reduce soil blow-over during windy periods. This was also echoed by the 2025 CSIR-NEERI joint study, as it flagged poor maintenance and visible dust accumulation along major road stretches, particularly at edges and medians. It called for improved road design, vegetative barriers, and greening using drip-irrigation methods from wastewater alongside metro infra, and a three-tier plantation system to stabilise loose soil and act as dust filters. Road dust is a major source of PM2.5 and PM10, the fine particles that can penetrate deep into the lungs and enter the bloodstream. Inhaling these particles can cause lung irritation and inflammation, and worsen pre-existing conditions such as asthma and chronic obstructive pulmonary disease, often leading to persistent coughing and wheezing. Long-term exposure to PM2.5 has been linked to premature death, particularly among people with chronic heart or lung disease, and to reduced lung function growth in children.

### Network-centric warfare

DRDO has partnered with Bharat Dynamics Limited and Adani Defence Systems and Technologies Limited for development and production. The Ministry of Defence said that the missile has been produced entirely through the Indian defence ecosystem, involving DRDO laboratories and several Indian companies. Officials said that the ULPGM-V3 has been developed primarily for the Army, with the air-to-ground mode for anti-tank roles and air-to-air modes for drone, helicopters, and other airborne targets. A senior Army officer said systems like ULPGM-V3 are key, as drones are increasingly becoming central to modern warfare worldwide. It also reflects the growing shift towards network-centric warfare, where drones, sensors, and command systems work together in real time to detect and strike targets with precision.

### What are lawyers advising?

“My recommendation is to hold off on filing an adjustment of status application and wait for clarity on how USCIS will implement this policy,” Williams said. “Indian clients cannot afford even a single immigration violation.” She warned Indians who already filed adjustment of status applications not to travel without legal consultation. Khanna said eligible Indians should file if their priority dates are current. “The memo does not prohibit approvals,” he said. But he emphasised that applicants now need to proactively tell their story: “Your application may now need to state your length of residence, your tax compliance, your community ties, your employer’s reliance on your work, your family circumstances, and your clean record.”

• CULTURE

# International Booker Prize at 10: Taking stories across borders

Paromita Chakrabarti  
New Delhi, May 24

“...TRANSLATION ALLOWS writing to transcend the limits of time and space. I believe in literature’s power because, in the life of the mind, literature has never ceded ground nor given up on the dialogue between people,” Yang Shuang-zi, one half of the winner of this year’s International Booker Prize for her novel *Taiwan Travelogue* — translated into English from Mandarin Chinese by Lin King — said at the award ceremony on May 19. What the 41-year-old writer was articulating was not merely literature’s ability to forge connections, but also the fact that to be monolingual is to hear, at best, half the conversation the world is having with itself. One of the world’s most influential awards for fiction in English translation, the International Booker Prize, that marks a decade in its current form, has worked to reward writers who write against the grain of the global literary market, of translators who carry stories across the distance of languages, and of readers who refuse to be circumscribed by familiarity.

### Road to reinvention

Launched in 2005 as the Man Booker International Prize, it was a biennial honour awarded to a writer for their entire body of work. Its early recipients, Ismail Kadare, Chinua Achebe, Alice Munro, Philip Roth and László Krasznahorkai, were already literary behemoths and the Prize only served to confirm their stature.



Yang Shuang-zi and Lin King at the prize ceremony. BOOKER PRIZE FOUNDATION

### • PICKING WINNERS

- In 2025, all six books on the shortlist were published by independent publishers
- Sheffield-based And Other Stories, which published *Taiwan Travelogue*, also published last year’s winner, *Heart Lamp*

transformation: the £50,000 prize would be shared equally between author and translator. It acknowledged, formally, that translation is not a mechanical service but a creative act. The translator, for long the invisible figure in world literature, was finally given a seat at the table. Before that, their names would often be missing from the book jacket. The first winner under the new rules was Han Kang’s unsettling and luminous *The Vegetarian*, translated from Korean by Deborah Smith. In the decade since, the Prize has honoured works from Arabic, Dutch, Polish, Bulgarian, Kanada and more. Last year, Indian writer Banu Mushtaq and translator Deepa Bhashti won the award for a collection of short stories, *Heart Lamp*. In 2022, Geetanjali Shree and Daisy Rockwell won for the novel *Tomb of Sand*.

### A decade of winners

The International Booker Prize has also worn politics on its sleeves, showing a preference for fiction that grapples with the weight of history — Olga Tokarczuk’s associative, nomadic *Flights* (2018); Jokha Alharthi’s *Celestial Bodies* (2019), a tapestry of Omani life across generations; David Diop’s *At Night All Blood Is Black* (2021), a harrowing meditation on colonial violence. It has championed formally daring, structurally restless books that reflect some of the world’s anxieties — war, displacement, memory, gender and the weight of the past.

### The Nobel connection

No measure of the Prize’s impact is more striking than the fact that four authors recognised by the International Booker Prize have gone on to receive the Nobel Prize for Literature: Kang, Tokarczuk, Annie Ernaux and Jon Fosse.

### Indie publishing boom

Since 2016, sales of translated fiction in the UK have doubled. Independent publishers, those risk-taking imprints guided by passion and a growing appetite for world literature, form the bulwark of the Prize, by drawing attention to fiction from literary cultures marginal to mainstream Anglophone publishing.

• GLOBAL

# Amid tighter Green Card rules in the US, why Indians could be uniquely affected

Vidheesha Kuntamalla  
New Delhi, May 24

THE US ON Friday moved to significantly restrict those eligible for permanent residency in the country, rattling the lakhs of Indians on temporary visas who are awaiting a Green Card.

The US Department of Homeland Security, which oversees the US Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS), announced that those applying for Green Cards must return to their home countries to do so — a sweeping reversal of a practice in place for over half a century. People can apply for Green Cards in two ways — going to a US consulate abroad, or applying while already in the US, which is called an “adjustment of status”. The new

USCIS policy memo targets the second, more popular route, used by Indian workers on H-1B visas, students transitioning from F-1 visas, and spouses on H4 dependent visas. Indians also dominate the decades-long backlog in employment-based Green Card categories such as Employment-Based Second Preference (EB-2) and EB-3.

### What has changed?

Immigration lawyers say the USCIS memorandum makes adjustment of status significantly more discretionary. Until now, eligible professionals could file Form I-485 and continue living and working in the US while the application was processed. But the memo now instructs officers to treat “adjustment of status” as “an extraordinary act of administrative grace”.

“Applicants must now demonstrate what the memo calls ‘unusual or even outstanding equities,’” Rajiv Khanna, an immigration attorney based in Washington DC, told *The Indian Express*. “A clean record and full eligibility are no longer sufficient on their own. You must affirmatively show why you deserve this ‘grace.’”

### What happens to Indians?

Indians are uniquely trapped in America’s employment-based immigration backlog. They overwhelmingly dominate the EB-2 and EB-3 employment backlog categories for securing permanent residency. “The wait for many of them exceeds 20 years,” said Khanna. During those years, many would have built entire lives in America — buying homes, paying taxes

and building careers — with the expectation that if they followed the rules, a Green Card would follow. Now, lawyers say, the very fact that they stayed in the US for years while waiting could become something immigration officers scrutinise negatively. According to Asel Williams, founding immigration attorney at the New York-based firm Williams Law firm, any push to have Indians return home to apply for the cards could create “enormous” appointment backlogs. “USCIS is currently adjudicating millions of ‘adjustment of status’ applications for foreign nationals physically present in the US. Redirecting even a fraction of those, potentially hundreds of thousands of Indian cases, to consular posts would overwhelm a State Department that

simply does not have the resources to absorb that volume,” Williams said. Khanna said, “Consular officers in India have, over the past several years, placed a significant number of employment-based immigrant visa applicants into administrative processing... There is no transparency about what triggers it or when it will end.” These delays are likely by design, in line with the Donald Trump administration’s push to restrict immigration. Khanna added that an applicant who leaves the US for a visa interview could suddenly find themselves stranded in India indefinitely, “sometimes without the ability to continue their employment at all.” Williams also warned that delays in consular processing could cause employers to pull back on job offers.

• DEFENCE

# DRDO’s new missile offers precision strikes, anti-drone combat

Sushant Kulkarni  
Pune, May 24

THE DEFENCE Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) last week carried out final development trials of the UAV-Launched Precision Guided Missile (ULPGM)-V3. This will be followed by user trials by the armed forces.

### Significant upgrade

A DRDO scientist said that compared with the V1 and V2 variants, the ULPGM-V3 represents a significant advancement in India’s indigenous drone-launched missile capability. The V1 was a basic free-fall precision missile and the V2 introduced propulsion, longer range, and mid-course target updates. The V3 adds the ability to engage both ground and aerial targets, including drones and helicopters. It also features



Development trials of ULPGM-V3 at DRDO’s test range in Kurnool. PIB

more advanced target-seeking systems, improved day-and-night combat capability, and multiple warhead options for different battlefield roles, making it a far more versatile weapon for modern drone warfare. The ULPGM-V3 is fitted with an ad-

### The new battlefield

- Development of drone-launched weapons will be one of the DRDO’s focus areas
- Drones are important for both conventional conflicts and asymmetric warfare involving smaller, highly mobile threats

vanced guidance system using multiple sensors to accurately track targets, allowing it to strike a wide range of threats. It can be deployed in both plains and high-altitude regions in the day or night. It is equipped with a two-way data link, enabling operators to change or update the target even after the missile has been launched. Depending on the mission, the missile can be fitted with three types of warheads. These include an anti-armour warhead designed to destroy heavily protected tanks and armoured vehicles, even those fitted with special layers of protection used in modern battle tanks. It also has a penetration-cum-blast warhead meant to pierce and destroy bunkers and fortified structures, and a pre-fragmentation warhead that disperses high-speed metal fragments over a large area to maximise damage. The missile can engage both stationary and moving targets in all weather conditions.



THE CENTRAL BANK CUT ITS RISK BUFFER TO 6.5% FOR FY26 CITING MACRO FACTORS

# Cut in RBI's risk buffer raised dividend to Centre by Rs 92K cr

Siddharth Upasani  
New Delhi, May 24

THE CENTRAL board of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Friday approved the transfer of a record Rs 2.87 lakh crore to the Centre as surplus — or dividend — for 2025-26. But it would have been much lower had the board not reduced a key risk buffer to 6.5% from 7.5%.

The RBI said its board decided to keep the Contingent Risk Buffer (CRB) at 6.5% of the central bank's balance sheet — which expanded 20.6% in 2025-26 to Rs 91.97 lakh crore — “taking into consideration the current macroeconomic factors, financial performance of the Bank and maintenance of appropriate risk buffers”. According to calculations by *The Indian Express*, had the CRB been maintained at the 2024-25 level of 7.5%, the dividend to the Centre would have been around Rs 92,000 crore lower at Rs 1.95 lakh crore.

When the CRB is lowered, the amount the RBI must transfer to its Contingency Fund — a rainy-day fund meant to meet unexpected and unforeseen contingencies, includ-

ing depreciation in the value of securities the central bank holds, risks arising out of monetary and exchange rate policy operations, and systemic risks — decreases. This raises the dividend payable to the Centre.

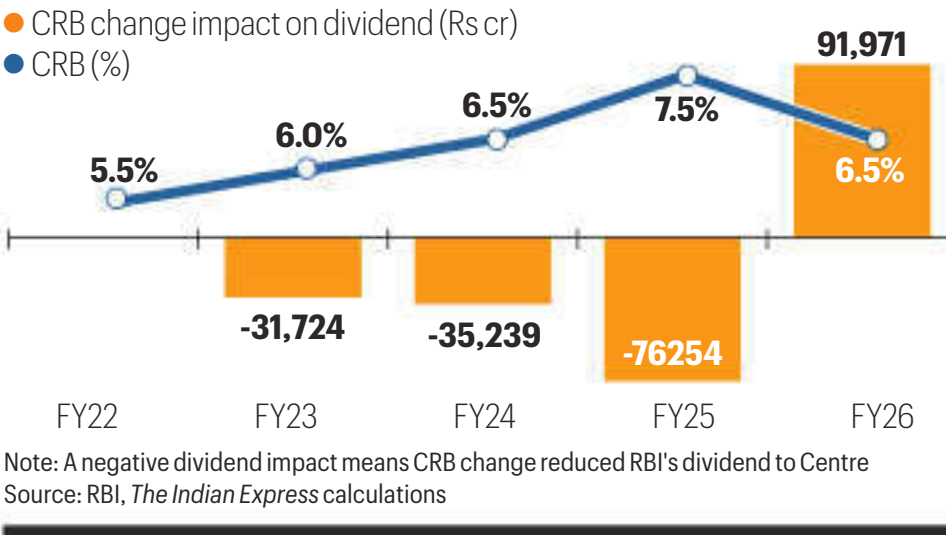
Last year, the RBI had internally reviewed its Economic Capital Framework and the board approved widening the CRB range to 4.5-7.5% of the balance sheet from the 5.5-6.5% recommended in 2019 by an expert committee led by former governor Bimal Jalan.

The Economic Capital Framework provides a rule-based system for the provisions the RBI must make against the risks it faces. These provisions are to be made from the revenue it generates in the normal course of its operations and after it has met its expenses. The Contingent Risk Buffer, or CRB, comprises the RBI's provisions to cover any potential risks — be it credit, operational, financial, or related to monetary stability — and is the proportion of the balance sheet that must be set aside as a buffer.

## Strains of war

Over the years, the RBI's

## • Changes to the CRB can raise, or lower, RBI's dividend to the Centre



dividend has become an increasingly important source of income for the government and now makes up around 8% of its revenue receipts, up from around 5% a decade ago. And the increase in the dividend due to the lowering of the CRB to 6.5% will be an enormous source of relief to the government whose finances have been stretched by the West Asia war: a rise in the fertiliser subsidy bill, a hit to tax collections because of cuts to the reduction in excise duty on petrol and diesel, and likely lower dividends

from public sector oil marketing companies who are incurring heavy losses.

According to Gaura Sengupta, IDFC First Bank's Chief Economist, the West Asia war poses a fiscal slippage risk to the Centre of around Rs 1.6 lakh crore — or 0.4% of GDP — assuming the Rs 10 per litre cut in petrol and diesel excise duty is only for six months. The Centre is targeting a fiscal deficit of 4.3% of GDP for the current fiscal.

## CRB and the dividend

This is the first time the

RBI's board has ever reduced the CRB and comes after it was raised three years in a row.

When the CRB is raised — as it was in 2022-23, 2023-24, and 2024-25 — the amount the RBI must transfer to the Contingency Fund increases. This reduces the dividend the Centre gets.

In 2024-25, the RBI's balance sheet grew to Rs 76.25 lakh crore; 7.5% of this is equal to Rs 5.72 lakh crore, which was maintained across the various funds of the central bank: the Contingency Fund, Asset Development Fund, capital, and Reserve Fund. These four together make up the RBI's Available Realised Equity (ARE). The ARE divided by the size of the balance sheet is equal to the CRB. Had the RBI retained the CRB for 2024-25 at 6.5% instead of raising it to 7.5%, the dividend to the government would have been higher by Rs 76,000 crore or so at Rs 3.45 lakh crore, calculations show. But with the Centre's finances in a good position last year, there was no need for an outsized dividend. As it is, even after the CRB hike, the dividend was a then record Rs 2.69 lakh crore.

## FULL REPORT ON

[WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM](http://WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM)

# How NHAI plans to decongest Delhi with 10 upcoming projects

Dheeraj Mishra  
New Delhi, May 24

THE MINISTRY of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH), along with the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI), will begin work on key projects by the end of the year to decongest the national capital, Union Minister Nitin Gadkari said last week.

After inspecting the six-lane access-controlled DND-Faridabad-Ballabgarh corridor with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Gadkari outlined the status of 10 upcoming projects covering 186 km at a cost of Rs 34,800 crore. These projects have been specifically planned to decongest Delhi by diverting freight traffic and providing connectivity to key centres in the region such as the Noida International Airport. The 59-km, 6-lane DND-Ballabgarh corridor is nearing completion and will connect to Delhi-Mumbai Expressway and Western Peripheral Expressway.

## Why congestion is a challenge in Delhi?

Despite the continuous development of metro network and increase in buses, the traffic congestion has remained a challenge for Delhi.

It is due to multiple factors like diverse socio-economic issues, population growth, increasing number of private vehicles, cargo vehicles etc.

A Delhi traffic police survey in March 2024 identified congestion at 134 locations or stretches, mainly due to ongoing construction works by various civic agencies, encroachment and heavy traffic volume. The agency also found 128 bad conditioned/potholed roads and 97 damaged/en-

## • NEW CORRIDORS

• The projects will cover 186 km at a cost of Rs 34,800 cr, and have been planned to decongest the city by diverting freight traffic

• They will provide connectivity to key centres in the region such as the Noida International Airport

• 59-km, 6-lane DND-Ballabgarh corridor is nearly complete, and will connect to Delhi-Mumbai Expressway and Western Peripheral Expressway

croached footpaths.

While the problem requires a multi-layered solution involving civic and state authorities, one of them is to divert the cargo vehicles not destined for Delhi, away from the city's roads.

MoRTH and NHAI are primarily responsible for the development and maintenance of the National Highways. However, it has an integral role to play in decongesting Delhi by diverting cargo vehicles.

These highways projects for decongestion are a transit route for the cargo and other vehicles to other states without entering the city.

## What are these projects?

The highway ministry prepared a Delhi Decongestion Plan in 2015. It involved the construction of expressways, ring roads, tunnels, elevated corridor for a modern transport network, which not only provide hassle-free movement, but also saved fuel.

One of these upcoming key projects are connecting Urban Extension Road-II (UER II) to Delhi-Dehradun Expressway.

The 17-km and six lane project will connect the newly opened expressway near Tronica city in Ghaziabad. Gadkari said the alignment of the project is in the final stage and its work will tentatively begin by December.

“This will help in reducing the traffic congestion on stretches IGI Airport, Barapullah Nala, Mukarba Chowk, Singhu border, Ashram-Badarpur. Also, areas like Dwarka, Rohini, Punjabi Bagh, Gurugram will get direct connectivity with Dehradun expressway,” he said. Another similar project is 65-km highway from Delhi-Dehradun expressway to Noida-Faridabad, also scheduled to begin by December. The project will act as an integration corridor connecting Delhi-Dehradun, Delhi-Meerut, DND, Faridabad and Yamuna Expressway.

The other proposed project, as part of Delhi Decongestion, is Delhi-Amritsar-Katra connectivity to UER-II, where the work will tentatively begin by March 2027. “With this project, the traffic coming through Delhi-Katra expressway will be diverted to UER-II and Dwarka Expressway. It will help in heavy traffic diversion and make freight movement more efficient,” the minister said.

The Centre has also proposed building a 8-km, 6-lane tunnel from Shiv Murti (near airport) to Nelson mandela marg at a cost of Rs 7000 crore to provide signal-free connectivity to Vasant Kunj via Dwarka Expressway. Gadkari said Public Private Partnership Appraisal Committee (PPPAC) approval for the project has been received and the work will begin after the final cabinet approval. **FULL REPORT ON** [WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM](http://WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM)

## • Rupee at 100/\$, RBI rate hikes on the horizon?

• The rupee's baseline exchange rate level is now 96-per-dollar, according to Japan's MUFG Bank, which is predicting the 100-mark could be breached in a 'severe' case scenario of the West Asia war lasting longer and leading to global crude oil prices averaging \$120 per barrel.



• It is in the backdrop that MUFG Bank is forecasting the Reserve Bank of India may increase the repo rate by at least 50 basis points in 2026-27. “In risk scenarios we think RBI may bring terminal rates up to between 6.25% to 6.75%,” Michael Wan, Senior Currency Analyst at MUFG Bank, said. The repo rate is currently at 5.25%.

## WE CONTINUE TO SEE THE INDIAN RUPEE AS VULNERABLE WITH USD/INR LIKELY BREACHING

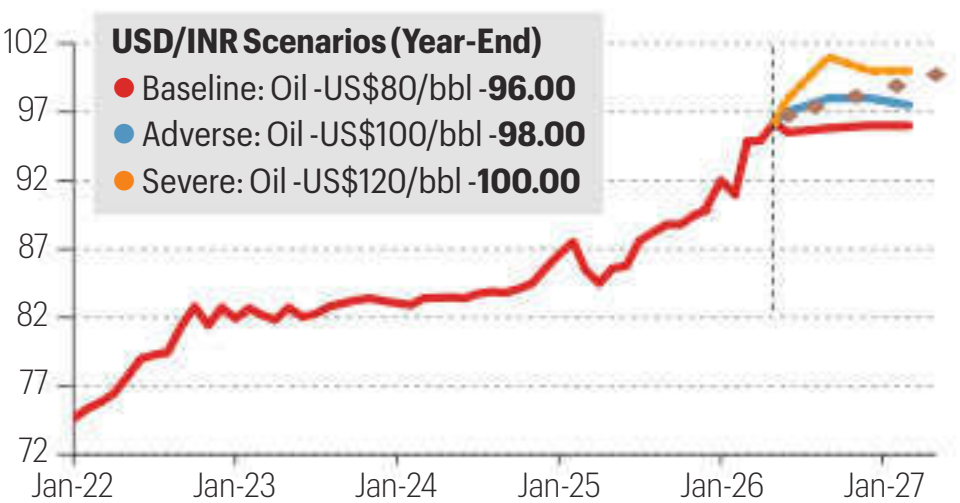
**USD/INR Oil and Strait of Hormuz Cases**

• USD/INR - Baseline forecasts: Oil: US\$80/bbl

• Adverse Scenario: Oil - US\$100/bbl

• Severe Scenario: Oil - US\$120/bbl

• Onshore USD/INR Forwards



# Align education, skills with evolving economic needs: NITI Aayog CEO

Press Trust of India  
New Delhi, May 24

NITI AAYOG Chief Executive Officer (CEO) Nidhi Chibber has underlined the importance of continued efforts towards aligning education, skilling, and employment ecosystems with the evolving requirements of the economy, according to an official statement.

On 22 May, NITI Aayog convened the first meeting of the High Powered ‘Education to Employment and Enterprise

Standing Committee’ under the chairpersonship of Chibber.

Speaking at the meeting, Chibber observed that India's demographic dividend presents opportunities to accelerate growth through appropriate policy measures to create productive employment and entrepreneurial opportunities for the youth.

According to the statement, the Committee noted that the services sector continues to play a pivotal role in the economic development,

and highlighted its growing contribution to economic resilience, export competitiveness, employment quality, global value chains, and potential to contribute to the vision of a Viksit Bharat.

The Committee decided to meet at regular intervals and focus on identifying actionable recommendations to enhance employability, foster entrepreneurship, strengthen industry-relevant skilling, and accelerate growth in the services sector.

• WEST ASIA ENERGY SHOCK HAS PRECIPITATED A CRISIS IN INDIA, WITH FOREIGN INVESTORS EXITING FINANCIAL MARKETS AND RUPEE TUMBLING TO FRESH LOWS ALMOST EVERY WEEK

# Trump rating sinks: Why Indian mkts are pinning hopes on US midterm elections

Siddharth Upasani  
New Delhi, May 24

LAST WEEK, the *New York Times/Siena* poll of registered US voters showed that Donald Trump's approval rating had slumped to 37%, the lowest in his second term as President, with nearly two-thirds of voters saying his decision to go to war with Iran was wrong.

More importantly, 69% of voters disapproved of how the Republican is handling the cost of living. And the Indian market's hopes are pinned on Trump being sufficiently concerned with his ratings to focus on home.

“We are positioned for the war to end,” Seshadri Sen, Head of Research & Strategist at

Emkay Global Financial Services, said on May 19. Sen, who has a target of 29,000 for the Nifty by the end of 2026-27 — 22% higher than Friday's close of 23,719.30 — assumes the Strait of Hormuz will reopen and the energy markets will normalise in a month or two.

“As we approach the midterms, it will be unsustainable for the Republicans and the US government to have pump prices ruling where they are and political pressure will start to get very intense on the US administration to reach a conclusion to the war,” Sen said, admitting that Emkay's views “may sound a little bit out of sync with today's reality, but we are looking ahead”.

Of course, there is a negative



US President Donald Trump's approval rating had slumped to 37%, according to the *New York Times/Siena* poll. **REUTERS**

scenario which exists, albeit with a low probability. Should the war go on for three more months, then “all bets are off”: interest rates will rise, consumption will slow, input costs

will rise, company margins will get affected, and Nifty could fall to 21,000.

## Pain in the USA

Sen's views echo those of

some policymakers, with Ram Singh, one of the six members on the RBI's MPC, telling *The Indian Express* earlier this month that a prolonged West Asia war is not in the interest of any country, including the US, where retail petrol prices, airfares, and government bond yields have surged.

Early November, the entire House of Representatives and a third of the Senate will head for elections. While Democrats need to gain three seats in the 435-seat House on a net basis to control it, they need four net wins in the 100-member Senate. And higher energy prices are burning a rather big hole in the pockets of US consumers — as per a new study by Brown University, each household has

on average spent over \$300 on petrol and diesel since February 28. This amounts to more than \$40 billion for the country as a whole. After surging 21.2% sequentially in March, gasoline prices in the US were up 5.4% month-on-month in April, helping propel consumer price inflation to a three-year high of 3.8%, which is seen crossing 4% in May. But it is not just prices that will be on voters' minds.

“Real wage growth is at best flat, hiring is slow, the labour force is shrinking and the University of Michigan consumer sentiment survey has recently reported the lowest consumer confidence on record in the survey's 74-year history,”

ANZ economists Brian Martin and Bansi Madhavani said on May 18. “Firms also reported slowing sales growth while plans to increase compensation in coming months are declining. For many consumers and businesses, the conflict in West Asia is offsetting the benefits of the One Big Beautiful Bill Act.”

## Foreign outflows

The West Asia energy shock has precipitated a crisis in India: with foreign investors exiting Indian financial markets in droves, the rupee has tumbled to a fresh record low almost every week. On May 20, the rupee nearly breached the 97-per-dollar mark and is down

5% since the war began. The Nifty has fallen 5.8% since February 27. Over the same period, Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) have pulled out \$23.8 billion on a net basis from Indian financial markets. Government bond yields have also jumped, with the war straining the Centre's finances.

“India's bond market has begun pricing in possible RBI rate hikes later this year, and foreign inflows into Indian bonds have slowed sharply — the 5-day moving average of net buying fell to just \$2.1 million against a 20-day average of \$47.2 million,” Michael Wan, Senior Currency Analyst at Japan's MUFG Bank, said on May 19.

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GETTYIMAGES

Warm nights disrupt the body's reset mechanism

## Delhi's hot nights are becoming a health risk

Night temperatures are disrupting sleep and stressing the heart

Ankita Upadhyay

AT 2.30 AM, 42-year-old Neeraj Sharma woke up drenched in sweat in his East Delhi apartment. The fan was running at full speed and the AC was set at 24°C, but the room still felt suffocating. He drank water, splashed his face and tried going back to sleep. By morning, he had a pounding headache, fatigue and dizziness severe enough to force him to skip work. "My body never gets a chance to recover anymore," he says.

Neeraj's experience is becoming increasingly common across Delhi this summer, where residents are not just battling punishing daytime temperatures but unusually warm nights — a phenomenon during which minimum temperatures remain significantly above normal, trapping heat in densely built urban areas long after sunset. Human beings are biologically designed to cool down at night. "During prolonged heat waves, survival is not only about avoiding the afternoon sun, it is also about ensuring the body can cool and recover overnight. During sleep, the body's core temperature drops, helping trigger deep, restorative sleep and allowing organs to recover from daytime stress. But when temperatures remain excessively high after dark, that natural cooling mechanism gets disrupted. Heat illness is not caused by temperature alone; it occurs when the body's natural cooling system can no longer keep pace with environmental stress," says Dr Neeraj Nischal, professor of medicine, All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), Delhi. "We often focus on daytime temperatures but persistently warm nights may be equally important predictors of heat-related complications. People continue to experience heat stress even while resting," he adds.

One of the earliest consequences is disturbed sleep. People often struggle to fall asleep, wake up repeatedly through the

**Even while asleep, the body continues sweating in an attempt to cool itself. This leads to loss of fluids and electrolytes**

during prolonged heat waves.

Even while asleep, the body continues sweating in an attempt to cool itself. This leads to continuous loss of fluids and essential electrolytes such as sodium and potassium. "The human body depends on cooler nights to restore thermal balance. When night temperatures remain elevated, the body continues to sweat and lose fluids even during sleep, increasing the risk of dehydration by morning," Dr Nischal explains.

The cardiovascular system comes under strain. To release excess heat, the body pushes more blood toward the skin surface, forcing the heart to work harder even during sleep. This additional stress can become dangerous for people with hypertension, heart disease, diabetes or kidney disorders. Your resting heart rate could go up by roughly 10 beats per minute for every 1°C rise in internal body temperature. As blood vessels widen to radiate heat, your BP could drop low. For those with pre-existing heart conditions, the combined stress of elevated temperatures, high humidity and poor sleep can trigger irregular heartbeats, heart failure or heart attacks.

Dr Nischal warns that some commonly prescribed medicines may further increase vulnerability. "People taking medications such as diuretics for hypertension may face a greater risk because these worsen dehydration. Such individuals may lose fluids overnight and begin the next day with an already reduced water balance."

Children and the elderly remain among the most vulnerable groups. They may not recognise or communicate symptoms of heat stress early enough, while older adults often have a diminished ability to regulate body temperature through sweating. "By the time confusion, dizziness or reduced sweating appear, the condition may already be serious," Dr Nischal says. His advisory: Maintain hydration through the evening, ensure ventilation indoors, wear loose cotton clothing, avoid heavy meals late at night, pre-cool rooms with blackout curtains and use cooling methods such as fans, cool showers or damp towels before sleep.

Rinku Ghosh

REMEMBER every patient I have lost and I have always put myself in their position, swapped their families with mine and visualised how they would react in similar conditions. And I have seen the good fight from ordinary patients, seen how their minds never give up till the end. Each of them has taught me more than just science — humanism," says Dr Cyriac Abby Philips, the Kerala-based hepatologist, better known online as "The Liver Doc." Few doctors in India inspire as much admiration and irritation in equal measure as him.

On social media, he has built a formidable reputation as a crusader of scientific medicine, dismantling wellness fads, calling out dubious supplements, questioning Ayurveda's unchecked claims and taking on an industry far larger than himself with the solidity of a data analyst and the aggression of a street fighter. Often considered a maverick, Dr Philips says, "On social media, you need to be loud to be heard so that real science has an audience. It's sad that what I say is what any doctor and man of science would say." But in the real world, as a student of the classical history of medicine, he goes back to the original meaning of the word doctor — an instructor. And that's what he does by the patient's bedside, helping them and their families beat death, understand it, endure it and sometimes, even find dignity within it, stories of which have made up his new book, *The Liver Doctor: Stories of Love, Loss and Regeneration*.

That's why, despite being trained at the Institute of Liver and Biliary Sciences in Delhi, he chose to return to Kochi where he works at the Rajagiri Hospital so that he can save ordinary lives from what is becoming the top 10 causes of death nationwide — liver disease. Yet it is silent and very few understand it. "There is a huge challenge in medicine and healthcare today, both for doctors and patients. I call it the loss of the true heart of medicine, which is humanism. The heart of medicine is empathy, and that is what medical training is actually supposed to offer. Now medicine is mostly business. I want to teach people how to live life," he says.

### What modern medicine should be

With the burden of healthcare being shouldered by the private sector rather than the public one and patients feeling like commodities, Dr Philips says he wants to reclaim that space where medicine feels the way it is supposed to feel — deeply caring, empathetic and compassionate. "There are very few diseases that doctors can truly cure. Infections are one example because we have antimicrobials. But beyond that, what can we cure completely? Most diseases we can only reverse, slow down, halt, manage, or improve life expectancy for. That is where the true practice of medicine shines. Treating a patient is not just diagnosing and prescribing medicines. It is about going on a journey with them. In my field, chronic liver disease patients stay with you for years — sometimes for life, until they die or undergo liver transplantation," he says.

The second reason for writing was personal. "The book became a way of decompressing emotionally. As a doctor, one of the hardest things is understanding limits. Patients come with expectations, but there are limits to what medicine can do. Sometimes you know the patient is not going to survive. First, you have to accept that yourself, and then you have to help the patient and family accept it too. That is how clinical medicine works for many diseases. For me, this book became a way to depersonalize all those

emotions I had internalised over the years," says Dr Philips.

### Why does the liver seem fickle?

Is sudden deterioration something unique to the liver? Someone can seem perfectly healthy and yet collapse suddenly. "This is what we call acute liver failure — where a perfectly healthy person suddenly develops severe liver failure and may even require ventilation support. Because the liver is the most resilient organ, has huge functional reserves or backup tissue and masks early distress, a person seems healthy until vital functions — detoxification and blood clotting — collapse, triggering sudden, life-threatening complications. This is triggered by sudden damage rather than long-term wear and tear and can be a result of drug toxicity, viral infections and autoimmune disorders," says Dr Philips.

### WHY LFT IS MORE MISLEADING THAN ACCURATE

DR PHILIPS warns against being content with just a Liver Function Test (LFT). "It is actually a misleading term. The liver has more than 500 functions and this test only provides limited information about inflammation or severe dysfunction. It does not measure liver performance. People need to pay attention to silent metabolic risk factors. Family history is extremely important because liver disease can skip generations. We have identified multiple families where cirrhosis appeared across generations due to genetic mutations combined with metabolic disorders. So,

watch out for diabetes, obesity, hypertension, high cholesterol, high uric acid and thyroid disorders. If these are present, the minimum screening should include blood count, LFT and ultrasound. If platelets are low, LFT is abnormal, or ultrasound shows fatty liver, further evaluation is needed, including Fibroscan."

**NEVER IGNORE HEPATITIS B AND C**  
EVERYONE SHOULD test for Hepatitis B and C at least once in their lifetime. North India has a high burden of chronic Hepatitis B. While Hepatitis B is preventable

### HOW TO PROTECT YOUR LIVER

There are specific tests you should take to understand liver performance and identify viruses. Also, you should not overdose on paracetamol

through vaccination, Hepatitis C is treatable with proper medications. Over half of people with Hepatitis B or C are completely unaware they are infected.

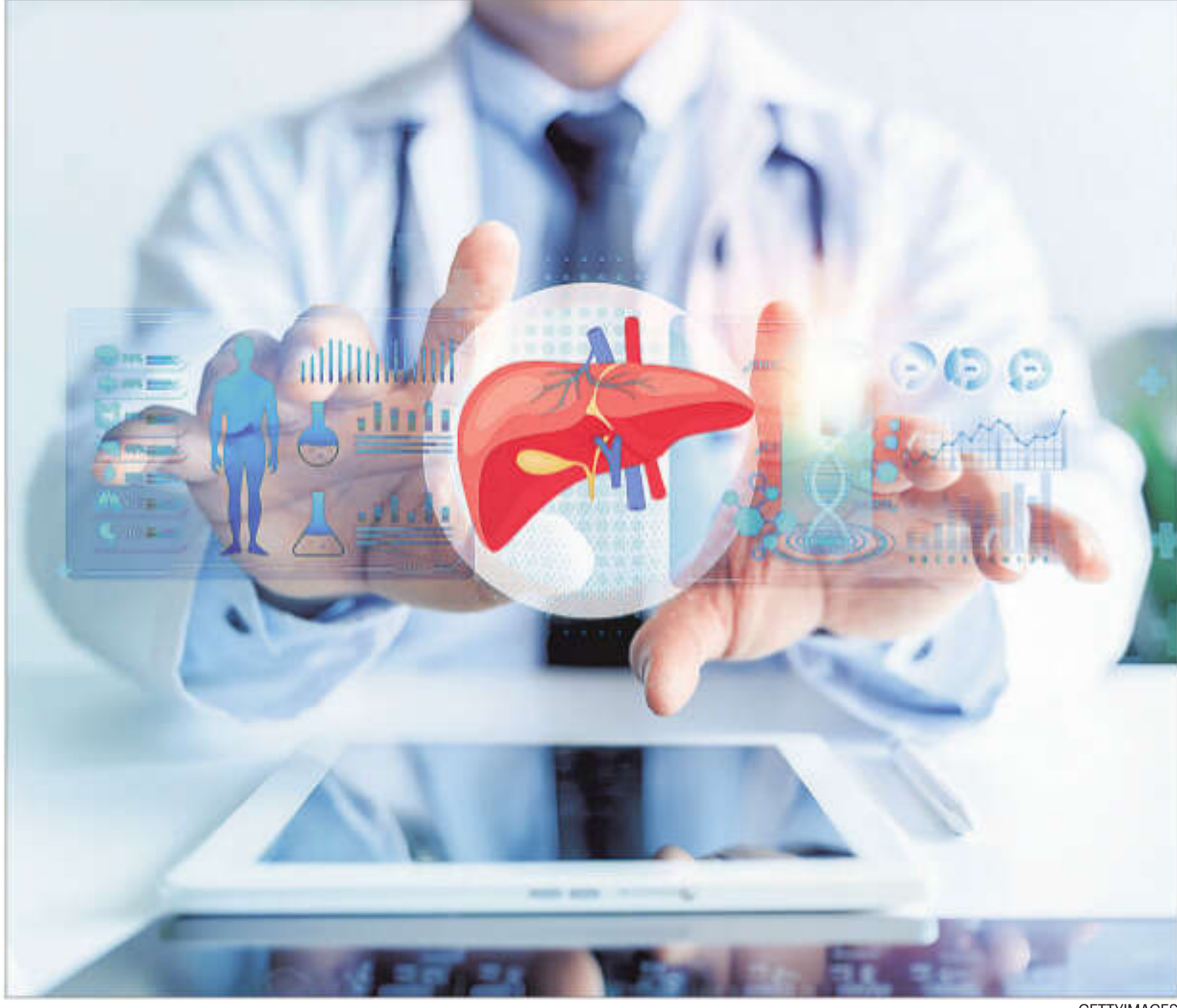
They can feel perfectly fine while the virus quietly attacks your liver. Left untreated, chronic infections significantly increase the risk of permanent liver scarring (cirrhosis), liver failure and liver cancer.

**PARACETAMOL VS DRUG-INDUCED LIVER INJURY**  
WHEN IT comes to drug-induced liver injury, Dr Philips cites several instances of paracetamol abuse. "It is one of the safest medicines available for pain and fever when used properly. Problems arise only when people take extremely large doses at one time — usually 8 to 10 grams or

more — often in cases of poisoning or suicide attempts. That is how it damages the liver. In the UK, paracetamol overdose is one of the commonest reasons for liver transplantation. Sometimes parents accidentally overdose children because they panic when a fever doesn't come down," says Dr Philips. For a healthy adult, a dose of 4–6 grams per day for 3–4 days is generally safe. For someone with chronic liver disease, the intake should be around 2–3 grams per day for 3–4 days. "Most don't come close to dangerous levels. A standard tablet is 500 mg. Even during fever, most people only take four or five tablets a day, which are usually safe. The danger comes from consuming very large doses," he says.

## Inside India's LIVER CRISIS

Hepatologist Dr Cyriac Abby Philips opens up about losing patients, fighting wellness myths, exposing unsafe supplements and why modern medicine is losing its human touch



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The second is acute-on-chronic liver failure, where someone already has chronic liver disease or cirrhosis (scarred liver because of hepatitis or alcohol use) and then suffers another injury or insult that pushes the organ into failure. "The first category patients find it often harder to reconcile emotionally because they are otherwise healthy individuals who suddenly become critically ill," he adds.

### Which hepatitis virus is most harmful?

Dr Philips sees a geographic pattern. "In North India, Hepatitis E is one of the commonest causes of acute liver failure followed by drug-induced liver injury. In South India, Hepatitis A is more common. Chronic viral hepatitis patterns differ geographically, too. Chronic Hepatitis B is very common in North India, whereas in Kerala, where I work, chronic Hepatitis B and C are less common," he says.

### Misinformation is bigger than the disease

Many liver diseases are actually preventable which, Dr Philips believes, become serious because of misinformation and lack of awareness. That's because the liver is the only organ capable of regenerating itself and even slight lifestyle modification in the early stages of damage — such as mild fatty liver or early-stage hepatitis — is enough. "People think only alcoholics develop liver disease, but that is not true. I have seen pa-

tients, who drank only socially or two to three times a week, developing cirrhosis. That's because even a safe amount of alcohol can be an accelerator if liver disease runs in the family. And Indians are predisposed genetically," says Dr Philips.

That's the reason why food and lifestyle matter too, topped with exercise. Dr Philips says that exercise doesn't mean signing up at a gym but 150 minutes of simple brisk walking, jogging, cycling or swimming a week. Obesity, diabetes, hypertension, hypothyroidism and metabolic disorders increase liver risk too. "Some factors are modifiable — sleep, exercise, diet, weight management. Genetics is not. If you control the modifiable factors, you reduce your risk significantly," says Dr Philips.

### Supplements, herbal pills and wellness culture

Dr Philips admits to being at the receiving end of bullying, harassment, trolling, and enormous pressure for upholding science and taking on unproven efficacies of herbal supplements and unregulated concoctions. "I begin the book with the case of a woman who died after having unregulated protein powder supplements thinking they would supplement her diet. She was just caught unawares. Ever since, blind faith in herbalists has been waning over the past five or six years because we now have data to prove everything. Data is the only way to fight belief systems. The challenge is that alternative medicine is tied to culture, religion, politics, and tradition. So, when you criticise it, people think you are attacking identity itself," says Dr Philips.

He has often been asked that if modern drugs originate from plants and natural compounds, why criticise ayurveda? However, drug makers use scientific methods to isolate beneficial compounds, determine safe doses, study side effects and test efficacy rigorously. "People lack critical thinking and some doctors do too. Critical thinking should be taught in schools and also be part of MBBS education. My biggest hurdle was not just fighting alternative medicine promoters, but dealing with members of my own profession who endorse it. Integrative medicine is just business, not patient care and functional medicine is nothing but sophisticated packaging of fringe medicine," he says.

Dr Philips rates alcohol and alternative medicine as equal risks for liver health, the only difference being people know that alcohol is a known poison and carcinogen while supplements are marketed as beneficial, healthy, and natural — often without evidence. "Nowadays makers even quote very small studies which aren't even peer-reviewed. This false sense of safety is dangerous." From a liver toxicity perspective, he has seen abuse of ashwagandha, giloy and turmeric supplements. "Turmeric in food is fine because absorption is naturally low. But the supplement industry modifies formulations using pepper extracts or nano-formulations to increase absorption dramatically. That becomes hepatotoxic. Italy has actually banned turmeric supplements because of liver injury cases. Same with ashwagandha. The youth take concentrated pills for muscle-building and end up damaging their liver," says Dr Philips.

As his Twitter followers crowd around for book signing at Kunzum Book Store in Delhi, he plays down his influencer status. "Doctors are fundamentally teachers. Medical education should not remain confined to outpatient departments. We should become educators and responsible content creators. Not influencers chasing monetisation but people sharing useful, evidence-based information. If more doctors did that, even five minutes a week, misinformation would reduce significantly," he says.



## FEDERATION CUP ATHLETICS

# How Tejaswin engineered a 8,000-point decathlon

## Speed gains, tactical reinvention, moving back to US and high jump peak of 2.25m power landmark show

## British Rail

Ranchi, May 24

ON A night of historic results, Tejaswin Shankar ran his heart out in 1500m, the last event of Decathlon and became the first Indian to cross the coveted 8000 points mark.

Tejaswin, who transitioned from high jump to combined events, is in the fourth year of doing Decathlon but the climb to this mountain of 8000 points started back in 2019 when he made a bet with his University buddy, Aaron Booth.

“Yes, you can say that my path for 8000 points started way back before I transitioned to Decathlon. Me and Booth would compete with each other in different events as part of fall tests during the school. I would always think what is special about Decathlon, I can also do it. But when I started doing it, I realized it is much more grueling and requires every bit of human ability to do combined events,” Tejaswin told *The Indian Express*.

Tejaswin, who competed in his first Decathlon in 2022 and scored 7592 points, is the 10th Asian ever to score over 8,000 points and ranks seventh on the continent's all-time decathlon list.

## Conquering Mt 8,000

After making his own plans and working on improving the national record in 2025, Tejaswin decided to move back to the US as a teaching assistant and started training under Kip Janvrin, an American coach with 26 Decathlons over 8000 points. "I was over analysing by sitting here and just doing sports. During my NCAA days, I used to do college and then do sports that would keep me fresh. I needed distraction and studying was that for me. So on advice of my wife Siddhi, I decided to move back to the US as a teaching assistant and started my masters in Kinesiology," said Tejaswin.

After moving to the US, Tejaswin started training under Kip and the first thing they worked on was speed improvement.

In Ranchi, Tejaswin recorded four personal bests (100m, Long Jump, 400m and 1500m) but had sub par performances in Javelin Throw and Shot Put.

"100m is the event that sets the tone for a Decathlete. It's the first event and if you do well, you carry that confidence and momentum to Long Jump, which is again about speed. When I did 10.59s at San Angelo earlier this year, it made me believe that I can improve in the 100m," said Tejaswin.

When he started training under Kip, the coach told him to improve his speed so a lot of things could improve automatically.

“Kip told me that you're an explosive guy but not crazy fast. If you improve your speed, it can improve a lot of your events as speed is the fundamental of events like Long Jump and Javelin,” said Tejaswin.

Tejaswin recorded a personal best of 10.77s in 100m and then went on to record another personal best of 7.67m in Long Jump.

"All the acceleration training done in the US came into play as I got the 100m PB and it set the tone. Long jump is also about speed as I don't have a technique. I just run and jump. I carried the confidence from 100m to Long Jump and Siddhi (a 100m sprinter herself) told me that you need to move two-three steps back from the board as you are running really fast on the runway, that's when I realised that I am in really good shape today," said Tejaswin.

Tejaswin, who transitioned from High Jump to Decathlon, always uses his strength in the event to score more points. In the last event of the first day, Tejaswin jumped 2.25m and became only the sixth Decathlete



Tejaswin Shankar moved to a training base in US and the first thing he worked on was his speed. EXPRESS

in history to touch the mark in high jump. "It felt pretty special that I'm only the sixth Decathlete to touch the 2.25m mark in high jump. It is my strong event which always helps me," said Tejaswin.

In the other events of the day, Shot Put (13.31m) and 400m (48.29s), Tejaswin did decently to score a mammoth 4511 points on Day one and set himself on course of 8000 points.

## Unpredictable Day 2

While his 4511 points were historic, the focus was on the second day where usually the Decathletes falter.

Tejaswin started with a good hurdles race clocking 14.23s but had a below par show in Discus Throw with 37.90m. "I wanted to throw 40m in Discus Throw as I believe there is an improvement round the corner in this event. I was doing good in practice but it just didn't come out at that time," he said.

The third event of the day was Pole Vault, an event which can be a nightmare for any Decathlete given the technicalities involved in the event and the delay in the event due to technical issues added more agony to it. Also, at the end of it, Tejaswin suffered a nasty fall that resulted in him getting a bandage on the knee.

"I'm extremely happy with the 4.20m in the Pole Vault.

This is not the first time I fell in PV. Earlier in one of the competitions, I fell off the mat and almost suffered a concussion,” said Tejaswin. “Another issue was the poles were too small to carry my weight. I usually vault with bigger poles but I didn’t have them here and the poles here were small to support my frame as I am a big guy,” he chuckled.

While his performance in PV was below his personal best, it didn't really affect him. It was the poor throw in Javelin that slightly cast doubts on the 8000 points target. "I had the mindset of 70m in Javelin and did well on the runway also but the throw didn't come only. I had two options after that- either sulking on the result or focus on 1500m," said Tejaswin.

All the calculators came out as he was placed at 7306 points after nine events.

"After the calculations I realised that I need to execute my 1500m plan and keep the body running. In 1500m, the fatigue can hit at the third lap and your body can shut down. It has happened to me in the past also," said Tejaswin.

As the calculators got clicking and the pressure mounted, Tejaswin knew the final 1500m would decide everything. He dug deep, kept his rhythm, and didn't let fatigue hit him crossing the finish line knowing that he had made history.